

Supply & Distribution Branch
Handbook (Customer Services)
Volume 2 - Complaint and Customer Services
(February 2026 version)



Water Supplies Department

Preface

Over the years, a large number of instructions and guidelines on customer services function have been issued to Regional staff in the form of (i) Departmental Instructions (DIs), (ii) S&D Branch Instructions, (iii) CS Branch Instructions, and (iv) CE/CS or CE/TS Instructions / Circular Memoranda / Emails. These instructions cover a wide range of subjects, each of which may involve a number of different instructions, and some of the content may have become outdated over time. In order to facilitate easy reference of Regional staff in identifying the latest instructions and guidelines on customer services, all the issued instructions in (i) to (iv) above relating to customer services (except for DIs that stipulate cross-branch issues) will be consolidated into the **Supply & Distribution Branch Handbook (Customer Services)** to be issued in three volumes, namely “Volume 1 - Application for Water Supply”, “Volume 2 - Complaint and Customer Services” and “Volume 3 - Field Works”. The S&D Branch Handbook (Customer Services) will be reviewed and updated annually. In between each update, any new policies and guidelines on customer services will be promulgated by means of Supply & Distribution Branch Instructions (Customer Services) and Circular Letters, which will be subsumed into the S&D Branch Handbook (Customer Services) in the next annual update.

Upon the issue of Volume 2 of the Supply & Distribution Branch Handbook (Customer Services) on Complaint and Customer Services in November 2020, all the instructions in items (i) to (iv) above (except for some DIs) concerning Complaint and Customer Services will be cancelled on the same date and all the staff when discharging duties relating to Complaint and Customer Services shall make reference to the documents listed below:

- (1) Waterworks Ordinance and Waterworks Regulations
- (2) Departmental Instructions No. 900 series
- (3) Supply & Distribution Branch Instructions (Consumer Services)
- (4) WSD Circular Letters
- (5) Supply & Distribution Branch Handbook (Customer Services)

All Regional staff handling Complaint and Customer Services are expected to be reasonably conversant with the above documents. If there are discrepancies between the Supply & Distribution Branch Handbook (Customer Services) and any other documents listed above, the provisions in the documents (i.e. items 1 to 4 above) shall prevail.

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Abbreviations

Abbreviations used in this handbook are as follows: -

A/P	Authorized Persons
ACCM	Assistant Call Centre Manager
ACCM/A	Assistant Call Centre Managers / Accounts
ACCM/A&SS	Assistant Call Centre Manager / Administration and System Support
ACCM/C	Assistant Call Centre Managers / Change of Consumership
ACCM/T	Assistant Call Centre Managers / Technical
ACO	Assistant Clerical Officer
AWI/Region(CS)	Assistant Waterworks Inspector / Region (Customer Services)
ArchSD	Architectural Services Department
BD	Buildings Department
CAS	Customer Accounts Section
CC Log	Customer Communication Log
CCBS	Customer Care and Billing System
CCM	Call Centre Manager
CEC	Customer Enquiry Centres
CE/Region	Chief Engineer / Region
CE/TS	Chief Engineer / Technical Support
CoC	Change of Consumership
CS	Customer Services
CSBI	Customer Services Branch Instruction
CSPM	Customer Services Procedure Manual
CSRs	Civil Service Regulations
CSO	Customer Service Officer
CSI	Consumer Services Inspector
CTEC	Customer Telephone Enquiry Centre
CWI/Region(CS)	Chief Waterworks Inspector / Region (Customer Services)
DCCM	Deputy Call Centre Manager
DEVB	Development Bureau
DI	Departmental Instruction

DMS	Digital Mapping System
DO	District Office
E/CC	Engineer/Customer Contact
E/Region(CS)	Engineer/Region(Customer Services)
EMSD	Electrical and Mechanical Services Department
EOT	Extension of Time
FEHD	Food and Environmental Hygiene Department
FWCT	Fresh Water Cooling Towers
Guidebook	Guide to Application for Water Supply
HA	Housing Authority
HAD	Home Affairs Department
HD	Housing Department
ICC	Integrated Call Centre
IQMS	Integrated Quality Management System
IQPM	Integrated Quality Procedure Manual
ITD	Immediate-to-do
ITDMU	Information Technology and Data Management Unit
ITPMRU	Information Technology Project Management and Review Unit
ITSP	Information Technology Security Policy
IVRS	Interactive Voice Responding System
JO	Joint Office
LP	Licensed Plumber
MO	Management Office
MR Section	Meter Reading Section
MRP	Mains Record Plans
OC	Owners' Corporation
PLO/PLM	Public Liaison Officer/Public Liaison Manager
PRU	Public Relations Unit
PU	Prosecution Unit
QP	Qualified Person
RA	Registered Agent
RC	Registered Consumer

RCC(CS)	Regional Complaint Centre (Customer Services)
RCC(D)	Regional Complaint Centre (Distribution)
RCC	Regional Coordination Centre
RPT	Reverse Pressure Test
SCSO	Senior Customer Service Officer
SE/CC	Senior Engineer/Customer Contact
SE/Region(CS)	Senior Engineer/Region (Customer Services)
SWI/Region(CS)	Senior Waterworks Inspector/Region (Customer Services)
S&DBI	Supply & Distribution Branch Instruction
TCA	Temporary Clerical Assistant
TC	Training Coordinator
TR	Technical Requirements for Plumbing Works in Buildings
TSD	Technical Support Division
UUs	Utilities Undertakings
WA	Water Authority
WHO	World Health Organization
WI/Region(CS)	Waterworks Inspector/Region(Customer Services)
WSc Division	Water Science Division
WSPB	Water Safety Plan for Buildings
WSMS	Water Suspension Management System
WVO	Waterworks Ordinance (Cap. 102)
WWR	Waterworks Regulations (Cap. 102A)
XRF	X-ray fluorescence

1. Good Practice of Handling Customer Complaints and Referrals

1.1 General

1.1.1 Diaries and Keeping Records of Individual Job Activities by Consumer Services Inspectors

- 1.1.1.1 All CSIs and AWIs in Customer Services Section have to keep diaries. To this end, they are each issued with a copy of diary at the beginning of the year. Diaries may be called by the officer's supervisor for scrutiny although regular submission of diaries to supervisors is not necessary. It is the duty of the supervisor to explain to his subordinate why scrutiny of their diaries is needed.
- 1.1.1.2 Diaries should not merely be a record of car mileage and attendance at the office but should include particulars of jobs and premises visited with brief notes on the findings of inspection and advice given to customers. Officers should also enter the essential details of emergencies or reminders of urgent business arising in the course of their duties.
- 1.1.1.3 CSI are required to keep time records on individual job activities due to the following advantages :-
- (a) the performance of outdoor and indoor works can be monitored;
 - (b) it gives opportunity to improve our services to the public;
 - (c) it provides a basis for possible charging of our services in future.
- 1.1.1.4 All CSIs are required to record the following details of their daily work in the diaries :-
- (a) case reference and location of the job;
 - (b) commencement / completion date and time of the job in the diary;
 - (c) nature of works involved, such as outdoor inspection, indoor office works, attendance of court hearings, etc.
 - (d) any other information which is considered essential by CSI.
- 1.1.1.5 The responsible Assistant Waterworks Inspector / Waterworks Inspector should regularly review the CSI diaries of his/her team and report to their seniors whenever necessary.
- 1.1.1.6 In order to simplify the recording process, CSIs may use appropriate abbreviations or short forms which are easily understood by their supervisors.

1.1.2 Handling Enquiries from Consumers During the Course of Inspection by Consumer Services Inspectors

- 1.1.2.1 From time to time CSIs may identify irregularities of inside services during the course of their inspection at consumers' premises. The CSIs should always be helpful in providing positive advice to the consumers to rectify the defects in their inside services. If the consumers raise enquiries which are apparently outside the sphere of expertise of the CSIs or if the CSIs may not be able to help immediately resolve the difficulties encountered by the consumers, they should direct the consumers' enquires to the appropriate telephone enquiry numbers or report the cases to their supervisors for assistance and advice. In this respect, the CSIs should be familiar with our WSD Enquiry Hotline (2824 5000).

1.1.3 Advisory Role of the Water Authority

- 1.1.3.1 The regulatory role of the Water Authority in respect of defective inside service/fire service leading to contamination, waste and misuse of the water supplied has been well established in Section 2.9.1 and our staff are familiar with it. However, the advisory role of the WA may not be so well taken by some of our staff.
- 1.1.3.2 It must be noted that we are not only concerned with those plumbing problems that are currently under our regulatory control, but we are also concerned with other plumbing problems encountered by the consumers. These problems include the frequent bursting of plumbing in a housing estate and the need to suspend water to a number of housing blocks for the repair work in individual housing block. Although in the beginning we may not exercise regulatory control, it is possible that with the accumulation of experience, we may evolve policies and regulations to curb these problems. By that time, our advisory role will evolve to a regulatory one.
- 1.1.3.3 Therefore, whenever we are aware of a water supply problem in the inside service or fire service, we should not hold the attitude that this is a matter solely responsible by the RC / RA / Occupier / Incorporated Owners / Building Management, Instead we, as the WA, should be seen to be concerned with such faults by taking positive and appropriate regulatory and / or advisory actions, which may include but not limited to conducting inspections, serving repair notices, holding discussions with the appropriate parties, giving our advice for resolving the problem through correspondences and informing the complainants of our action taken. For those cases that have aroused the interest of the public / media, we should make clear our position by responding to the public / media irrespective of whether a response from us has been requested by the public / media.

- 1.1.3.4 Experience in handling these problems and proposed solutions should be shared with other colleagues in the regional meetings, functional meetings and when the need arises, to be brought up to the management through CE/TS for policy review and / or amendment to the WWO, WWR, TR and Guidebook.

1.1.4 Reply Direct to Enquirers

- 1.1.4.1 In response to requests/queries from enquirers, officers shall reply to the enquirers direct rather than through other persons.

1.2 Data Privacy

1.2.1 Protection of Customer's Privacy

- 1.2.1.1 In the wake of the increasing public awareness of the importance of protection of personal data, staff at all levels should always exercise caution when handling enquiries and/or complaint cases lodged by customers, in a bid to avoid divulgence of personal data. If the enquiry or complaint case is needed to be handled by non-government party (for example, maintenance contractors of WSD), prior consent has to be obtained from the concerned customer before passing his/her personal data including name, telephone number, address, etc. to the relevant party handling the case.

In the event that the customer requests to handle his/her case in confidential manner, the case officer shall explain to the customer the established procedure of WSD, and try to have the consensus with the customer on the way in handling the case.

1.3 Complaint Register

1.3.1 Monitoring of the Handling of Customer Services Related Complaints

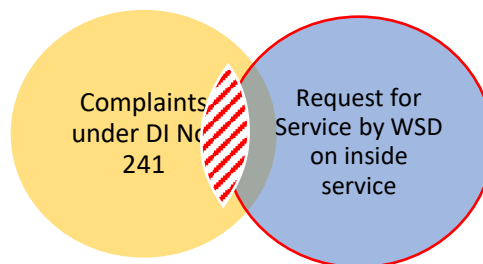
1.3.1.1 Definition

[Section updated in January 2024 version]

A CS related complaint (CS Complaint) refers to a complaint handled by CS staff (including Application Teams, Inspection Teams, and Works Teams) in Regions. It includes

- (a) Request for service from WSD on inside service, which require follow-up action by offices concerned (e.g. report of seepage, inside service leakage, unauthorized extension, etc.) that require follow-up actions (e.g. site visits, issuance of Repair or Disconnection Notices) by WSD should also be processed and recorded in the Complaint Register according to the guidelines and procedures set out in the following paragraphs; and
- (b) Complaints that fall within the definition of “Complaint” under DI No. 241, which contain element of an expression of dissatisfaction by the public with a departmental policy or services on CS matters, or the way in which a policy is implemented or service is delivered, including staff attitude, irrespective of the complaint channel used.

The element of complaints could be illustrated below. CS Complaints are those cases that are circled in red and all cases fall under these criteria should be recorded in the complaint register.



It excludes statutory appeals / objections / petitions to the Chief Executive, staff complaints, complaints about crime and corruption and complaints subject to statutory procedures.

If the CS complaint also contains other expression of dissatisfaction as stated in DI No. 241 (red hatched area in the illustration above), the procedure set out in the concerned DI should also be followed, which includes logging the case to Complaints Management System (CMS) in addition to the complaint register stated in this section. The cases that

are logged in CMS should also be recorded in the complaint register in **Appendix 1.1** for record.

The case officer for handling public complaints should exercise judgement to distinguish complaints from others like enquiries, technical fault reports etc. Case officers should seek advice from their supervisors if they have doubts in determining if the cases should be classified and handled as public complaints.

1.3.1.2 ***Sources of Complaints***

Complaints usually reach the Department in one of the following forms-

- (a) Hotline of the Customer Telephone Enquiry Centre (CTEC);
- (b) Letter / fax from the complainant or through LegCo Member / District Council Member;
- (c) Email to “wsdinfo@wsd.gov.hk”;
- (d) Customer Enquiry Centres (CECs);
- (e) Referral from 1823 Call Centre, other government bureau / departments (B/Ds), the Office of the Chief Executive, or public bodies (e.g. the Office of The Ombudsman, Legislative Council Secretariat, etc.); and
- (f) Telephone call / letter / email to individual officer direct from the complainant.

1.3.1.3 ***Recording of Complaints***

All written and verbal CS complaints, including anonymous complaints and referrals from other B/Ds or agencies, should be recorded consistently in a central complaints register (the Complaints Register) (**Appendix 1.1**) maintained by each CS/Region.

For consistency, CS/Regions should use the same definition as stated in sub-paragraph 1.3.1.1 above and the reporting arrangement below for recording complaints and compiling statistics:

Cross-department Complaints

These complaints should be recorded in the Complaints Register with a remark stating the B/Ds involved.

Cross-branch / section Complaints

These complaints should be recorded in the Complaints Register with a remark stating the branch(es)/section(s) involved. For the purpose of compiling departmental-wide statistics, cross-branch / section complaints should only be reported by the coordinating CS/Region.

Misdirected Complaints

These complaints should be recorded with a remark stating the branch / section to which the complaints were subsequently referred. For the purpose of compiling departmental-wide statistics, misdirected complaints should be reported by the section ultimately responsible for dealing with them.

Anonymous Complaints

Depending on the gravity of the allegations made, CS/Regions should treat certain anonymous complaints in the same way as signed complaints though it is not possible to acknowledge or reply to these complainants. CS/Regions should exercise common sense when an anonymous complaint is too vague to be able to identify sufficient details for a meaningful investigation to be conducted. Where criminal allegations are implied, referrals should be made to relevant law enforcement agencies as appropriate.

Request for Review

If the complainant is not satisfied with the substantive reply and does not consider that the subject problem has been resolved, he/she may raise a request for review. A request for a review should be considered by an officer who is more senior in rank than the one who has made decision in the original complaint, and, where possible, has not been directly involved in the investigation of the original complaint.

Repeated / Persistent Complaint

CS/Regions should pay attention to repeated operations-related complaints and to identify the reasons leading to repeated complaints and the specific locations which are more prone to complaint, and to take remedial / follow-up measures proactively. For systemic issues identified from repeated cases, they should be escalated to senior officer's attention as appropriate.

Some complainants may continue to lodge complaints on the same matters, even after action has been taken or reasonable explanation has been given to them. Others will try to find any irregularity in the way that a case is handled, and lodge complaint about the handling rather than the original matter at issue. Still others will use threatening or abusive language. Supervisors should not only ensure that the frontline staff has proper training and clear guidelines for handling such complainants, but should also back the staff up in responding politely but firmly to such complainants. Frontline staff should also be allowed to escalate a difficult complainant to supervisors and the senior management whenever necessary.

In the case of persistent complaint, where the complaint is repetitive and contains no new circumstance or information that would justify reopening the case, it may be escalated to senior management for a decision on whether the correspondence should be discontinued. Termination of correspondence on a complaint should only be taken if a substantive reply has been issued, all review or appeal procedures available have been exhausted, the senior management is satisfied that the complaint has been handled properly and in accordance with established procedures, and that further correspondence will constitute a waste of public resources.

1.3.1.4 ***Processing of Complaints***

Time Limits

All complaints received in whatever form and from whatever sources must be dealt with promptly. The quicker a complaint is handled the better. Wherever possible, frontline staff should try to resolve a complaint on the spot.

For general reference, an acknowledge of receipt of a written complaint in writing should be issued to the complainant as soon as possible and **no later than ten calendar days upon receipt of the complaint by WSD**, unless the complainant only requests an oral reply. If the case is referred from CTEC or any other Section who has already issued an acknowledge of receipt to the complainant, the CS/Region shall contact the complainant by phone or through any other means **within 5 working days** upon receipt of the referral to inform the complainant that the case will be followed-up by the CS/Region, and clarify / seek further information of the case from the complainant, if necessary.

While observing the time limits in respect of taking initial actions on various types of CS complaints which have been set out at **Appendix 1.2**, CS/Regions should strive to provide a substantive reply **within 30 calendar days** after receipt of the complaint by WSD. For complicated cases or cases of special nature which require longer processing time, the complainant should be kept informed of the progress of the case and the reasons why a longer time is needed to provide a substantive reply, and if possible, the estimated time frame. Further interim replies should be sent to the complainant at a bi-weekly to bimonthly interval as necessary depending on the nature of the complaint.

Priorities

CS/Regions should accord priority in accordance with the seriousness of the complaints, the length of outstanding time and the consequences of delay in handling.

Language

Written communication in connection with a complaint should be in plain language and in the same language in which the complaint was lodged. They should be written in simple and easily understood terms, and special terms and jargons should be avoided.

Substantive Reply

Upon receipt of a complaint, the responsible officer should identify the key concern(s) of the complaint and the information needed in preparing a reply. Reference should be made to previous replies and line-to-take on similar issue(s), if applicable. The responsible officer should be prudent and provide specific and sufficient details to address the concern of the complainant. The substantive reply should, as far as possible, contain all details necessary to explain to the complainant that the complaint has been properly dealt with, particularly if the outcome is unfavorable to the complainant. For cases which require a longer processing time, CS/Regions should make reference to the arrangements set out in the preceding paragraphs about **Time Limit**.

For verbal complaints, verbal replies will generally suffice but where written replies are required by verbal complainants, the complaints should be dealt with as if they are written complaints. Officers who convey verbal replies to complainant should also provide the CCID of the subject case for their reference, and log the conversation on CCBS as record.
[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

1.3.1.5 **Monitoring of the Handling of CS Complaints**

In order to have a better monitoring of the progress of the complaints and to facilitate timely intervention of senior officers in dealing with difficult or complicated complaints, the following reporting and monitoring mechanism is to be implemented.

1.3.1.6 **Complaint Coordinator and Complaint Recording Officer**

In the light of the large number of complaints handled by CS/Region, it is necessary to assign a Complaint Coordinator in each CS/Region to coordinate the compilation of the Complaints Register of each CS/Region, and to assist in consolidating / providing complaint-related information for statistical analysis and management information as and when required. Given that most of the CS complaints are handled by the Inspection Team, Engineer/ Inspection of CS/Region is therefore assigned as the Complaint Coordinator of respective CS/Region.

Each CS/Region should designate a Complaint Recording Officer (e.g. a clerical staff or PLM) to assist the Complaint Coordinator in compiling the Complaints Register and preparing periodical report for the management's monitoring.

1.3.1.7 ***Recording of Complaints***

CS complaints are received through various channels. Irrespective of its source, upon receipt of a complaint, the case officer should forward details of the case to the Complaint Recording Officer for recording in the Complaints Register.

When recording the case in the Complaints Register, the Complaint Recording Officer should check whether the case is a repeated complaint by making reference to the information available in the Complaints Register, and record such information therein. He/she should consult the case officer if in doubt.

1.3.1.8 ***Updating of the Complaints Register***

The Complaint Recording Officer is responsible for updating the Complaints Register. Subject to the workload of the Complaint Recording Officer and the practice in handling complaint of different teams, CS/Region may choose to adopt either of the following arrangements for updating the Complaints Register:

(a) Receiving updates from the case officer

The case officer shall inform the Complaint Recording Officer of any critical/significant progress (such as issuance of repair notice (Form WWO 48), conducting of Form WWO 48 inspection, issuance of disconnection notice (Form WWO 47), issuance of interim reply and substantive reply, etc.) in respect of the complaint by email, CCBS log, or through any other means. The Complaint Recording Officer should update the Complaints Register accordingly.

(b) Consolidating complaint records maintained by individual case officer

Individual case officers shall maintain their own complaint records and forward their individual complaint records to the Complaint Recording Officer regularly for a consolidated update of the Complaints Register at regular interval as determined by respective CS/Region but in any case not less than once a month.

1.3.1.9 ***Monitoring of Complaint***

The Complaint Recording Officer shall submit the Complaints Register and prepare reports to the supervisory staff for monitoring at interval as specified below:-

(a) Monthly report on complaints received

The Complaint Recording Officer should prepare a monthly report by using **Appendix 1.7** on complaints received to the respective Senior Engineer / Region (CS) (SE/Region(CS)¹) and CE/Region for monitoring. The SEs and CEs should review the report and identify the reasons leading to any increase in complaints of specific nature and the specific locations which are more prone to complaint, and to take remedial / follow-up measures proactively. Besides, they should give special attention to those repeated complaints such that timely intervention and /or advice / instruction can be given to the case officers for resolving the complaints and avoiding the complaints to snowball.

(b) Bi-weekly report on outstanding complaints

The report should be prepared by the Complaint Recording Officer by using **Appendix 1.8** and reviewed by the Complaint Coordinator. Normally, a substantive reply should be issued to the complainant within 30 calendar days as far as practicable. Notwithstanding, certain types of complaints may require a longer handling time given their nature. **Appendix 1.3** lists out the normal duration for processing complaints of different natures. The Complaint Recording Officer should highlight those cases that have taken longer time to complete than normal ¹ and refer them to the responsible Engineer or Chief Waterworks Inspector for attention.

(c) Monthly report on complaints that have been outstanding for more than 30 / 60 days

For complaints that have been outstanding for more than 30 / 60 days, the responsible Engineer or Chief Waterworks Inspector shall prepare monthly report on outstanding complaints to SEs/CS and CEs/Regions using **Appendix 1.9**. SEs/CS and CEs/Region should **personally** look into all complaints that have been outstanding for more than 30 days and 60 days respectively. They should look into the reasons for any long periods of overdue or inaction during investigation of the case and to give advice / guidance to their subordinates as necessary with a view to concluding the case as soon as possible.

(d) Half-yearly review on complaints statistics

CS/Regions should conduct review on the complaints received on a half-yearly interval and submit the review report by using **Appendix 1.10** to the respective

¹ SE/Region(CS) in the four Regions are SE/HK(4), SE/K(3), SE/NTE(4) and SE/NTW(3) respectively.

CE/Region and AD for information in January and July of each year. The review should include:-

- (i) Breakdown of the complaints by nature;
- (ii) Geographical distribution of the complaints;
- (iii) Number of complaints received and responded to within the normal duration for processing complaints as stated in **Appendix 1.3**;
- (iv) Number of complaints which were not responded to within the normal duration for processing complaints as stated in **Appendix 1.3** and the reasons for the delay;
- (v) Data comparing performance in the reporting period to previous periods;
- (vi) Suggestion and progress of initiatives taken to improve services; and
- (vii) Lesson learnt and special cases that worth sharing with other Regions.

Supervisors should ensure that complaint cases are handled appropriately from start to finish, and that complaints are properly and timely recorded in the Complaints Register. They should conduct sample checks on the completion of the complaints. They should also oversee the progress of the cases undertaken by their subordinates and make good use of the reports mentioned in the paragraph above for monitoring purposes.

Remark (1): The normal time for completing a complaint case should be counted from the date of receipt of the complaint by WSD to the date of issuing a substantive reply to the complainant.

1.3.1.10 *A Guide to Complaints Handling and Pubic Enquires*

Reference can be made to "A Guide to Complaints Handling and Public Enquiries" issued by the Efficiency Unit for good practices relating to complaints handling. The Guide is available on the website of the Efficiency Unit for viewing.

(http://www.eu.gov.hk/tc/reference/publications/A_Guide_to_Complaints_Handling_and_Public_Enquiries_tc.pdf)

1.4 Entering Private Premises for Investigation Purpose

1.4.1 Entering Private Premises

Details refer to DI No. 85.

1.4.2 Supplementary Guideline on Entering Private Premises for Investigation Purpose

- 1.4.2.1 In the discharge of their normal duties, Customer Service (CS) staff members are often required to enter private premises for investigation of complaints and / or cases related to suspected contravention of the WWO / WWR, and for taking necessary follow-actions.

When scheduling an inspection for investigation purpose, CS staff should observe the following guidelines:-

1.4.2.2 (i) Nature and seriousness of the complaint

In most situations, CS staff should attempt to schedule an inspection with the parties concerned advance. However, in circumstances where advance notice for entry might defeat the purpose of the entry and subsequent investigation (e.g. it is suspected to have illegal taking of water inside the premises), the case officer should consider applying for a magistrate's warrant of entry under Section 12 of WWO direct instead of making advance appointment for inspection.

1.4.2.3 (ii) Stalling action of the occupier/ RC

In general, once the case officer has got in touch with the occupier / RC of the premises under complaint, he should schedule an inspection with the occupier/RC soonest possible. In the event that the occupier/ RC requests to cancel or postpone the inspection, the case officer should critically assess whether the reason(s) given by the occupier/RC is/are reasonable and genuine. The case officer should be wary of being jerked around by the various excuses of the occupier/ RC for rejecting our inspection, in particular if the case is related to suspected contravention of WWO/WWR.

If the case officer is doubtful about the reason(s) given by the occupier/ RC for cancelling or postponing the inspection, or if the occupier/RC has already cancelled / postponed the appointment for more than once, the case officer should take a decisive approach and consider issuing a letter to the occupier / RC to request for entering the premises for inspection, or else we will apply for a magistrate's warrant of entry under Section 12 of WWO.

1.4.2.4 (iii) To seek the advice of supervisory staff

CS staff if in doubt should seek the advice of their supervisor(s) at professional rank and may escalate the case to the senior management for directive if necessary.

Meanwhile, when reviewing the Complaint Register, supervisory staff should watch out for cases which involved repeated attempts for inspection and provide early intervention if necessary.

1.4.3 Guidelines on Gaining Access to Repeatedly Inaccessible Water Meters and Inside Services

1.4.3.1 Some practicable ways and means to tackle cases of repeatedly inaccessible water meters and inside services (RIWMIS) encountered during our meter replacement, inspection and/or other work are promulgated in the ensuing sub-paragraphs for the following situations

- (a) Door-lock;
- (b) Obstruction;
- (c) Flooding; and
- (d) Disruption to business.

1.4.3.2 ***Door-Lock***

Quite often, water meters at some buildings are housed inside G/F shops, roof-top structures or meter rooms which might be locked. For buildings with MOs, we should have no problem in getting access to the meter rooms on G/F or R/F. For door-lock cases at G/F shops, we should try to dig out the contacts of the relevant shop owners from the CCBS. Seeking assistance from the relevant Customer Services Registry to help search for information on RCs and/or RA should be attempted if required.

Demolition Sites: contacts of the A/P and Site Agent should be available in Form WWO 1143 – Application for Water Meter Removal and Water Supply Disconnection due to Building Demolition – submitted to WSD and/or from the signs displayed on the site hoarding.

Properties for Sale or Rental: contacts of the relevant property agents might be available in the Sale/Rental Notices or advertisements posted on the premises. We might contact the property agent(s) for arranging access to the premises.

Properties possessed by statutory bodies or Government Departments: contacts of the relevant statutory bodies (such as the Urban Renewal Authority) or Government Departments (e.g. Housing Department) might be available in the notices displayed on the premises. We should contact the responsible officers for assistance in gaining access to the premises.

Other than the above, we might seek assistance from the MR Section in searching for possible contacts of the landlord or tenant of the premises concerned. MR Section's colleagues might have contacts not included in the CCBS, particularly those who recently have successfully gained access for meter reading.

If all possible means have been exhausted, we should issue the WWO 1142 (**Appendix 1.4**) together with a 'door lock' letter (**Appendix 1.5**) Letter to the relevant RC or occupier to appeal for their co-operation in letting or helping us gain access to the premises.

1.4.3.3 ***Obstruction***

This relates to those passages leading to water meters/inside services which are partially/fully obstructed/blocked by goods/equipment/ furniture inside the premises such as restaurants, groceries, garages, market stalls, cooked-food-stalls, bars, etc..

Firstly, we should issue WWO 1142 (**Appendix 1.4**), together with verbal/written advice to the RC or occupiers requesting them to remove the obstruction to facilitate our work. If positive response is not received, we should issue Form WWO 48 together with the details and photos (if available) of the obstruction to the RC or occupiers as appropriate.

1.4.3.4 ***Flooding***

This refers to those water meters/inside services partially/fully covered/flooded with litter or water at light-well or backyard. These cases are usually associated with seeping, leaking or bursting communal pipes which are badly corroded. Hence, several RCs might be involved. For buildings without MOs, we might need to serve notices on all associated RCs requiring them to rectify/relocate the water meters/inside services concerned. As multiple RCs might be involved, we should inform the relevant District Officers for assistance in co-ordinating the RCs to carry out the required rectification works.

Should broken / blocked drainage pipes be involved regardless of whether they are underground or exposed ones, we should alert FEHD and BD, via memo together with photos showing the details, for enlisting their assistance in addressing the issue.

1.4.3.5 ***Affecting Business***

Some occupiers of the premises (such as operators/proprietors of hotels, karaoke, restaurants, pubs, night clubs, etc.) are prone to decline our request for carrying out meter replacement work or inspection of inside services on the ground that we might affect their business. Under such circumstances, we should not only give the RC notice well in advance, but also, if the situation so requires, explain to him/her clearly the purposes and details of our work including the estimated duration and/or technically feasible alternative. To minimize the disruption to their business brought about by the inevitable temporary suspension of water supply to the premises, we should schedule our work/inspection to be carried out during their off-peak hours. If justified, we may consider performing the work/inspection outside our office hours.

1.4.3.6 ***Warrant for Entry into Premises***

Section 12 of the WWO empowers us to enter any premises to, inter alia, install, inspect, test, regulate, alter, repair or remove any part of the waterworks or any fire service or inside service therein subject to the following:

- (a) our admission to any premises has been refused, or refusal is apprehended, or the premises are unoccupied, or the occupier is temporarily absent, or an application for admission would defeat the objective of the entry;
- (b) there is a reasonable ground for entry into the premises for specified purpose(s); and
- (c) notice of the intention to apply for the warrant has been served on the occupier of the premises or such notice cannot be served because the premises are unoccupied or the occupier is temporarily absent, or serving of such notice would defeat the object of the entry;

The magistrate may by warrant authorizes the WA, or any person authorized by the WA in writing, to enter the premises.

Nevertheless, obtaining a warrant for entering premises should be considered as the last resort. The subject officer should observe Section 1.4.5 - Application for Warrant for Entry into Premises and duly consult their CWI, E and SE before taking such move.

1.4.3.7 **Monitoring**

The subject officers should keep reviewing long outstanding RIWMIS cases regularly and, if necessary, seek guidance from their supervisors (CWI/E/SE) as appropriate. Furthermore, all actions/attempts in gaining access to the relevant premises should contemporaneously be logged in the CCBS for record and reference.

1.4.4 **Supplementary Guidelines on Gaining Access to Repeatedly Inaccessible Water Meters**

1.4.4.1 Delay in replacing defective water meters will not only lead to complaint but also loss in government revenue. Regional staff should therefore endeavor to replace the defective meter **as soon as possible, and in any event, not more than three months.**

1.4.4.2 Section 1.4.3 provides a reference to regional staff for tackling cases of repeatedly inaccessible water meters encountered during meter replacement, inspection and/or other works. Regional staff are reminded that if all possible means have been tried but a defective water meter still remains inaccessible for replacement after **30 days**, they should **proceed to obtain a magistrate's warrant** for gaining access to the meter position under Section 12(3) of the WWO.

1.4.5 **Application for Warrant for Entry into Premises**

1.4.5.1 CS staff should contact the customer by telephone, if possible, for arranging a mutually convenient time before the inspection is carried out. However, if telephone arrangement cannot be made, staff shall go to inspect the premises as scheduled. If the premises are found locked or vacant, staff should complete WWO 1142 and leave it in the letter box or behind the door notifying the occupier of the visit made and requesting the occupier to contact our staff to arrange a joint visit.

1.4.5.2 If the correspondence address differs from the service address or no response from the occupier has been received, staff shall send a 'door lock' letter (**Appendix 1.5**) requesting the RC to contact our staff to arrange for a joint visit. The letter is issued to the RC and copied to the occupier.

- 1.4.5.3 In case response from customer has not been received within the period as specified in Table 1 below after the issue of the ‘door lock’ letter, and the premises is still inaccessible, staff should serve a letter to the RC and copied to the occupier, demanding the addressees to allow WSD staff to enter the premises for inspection of the inside service within a specified period as stated in Table 1. The letter should remind the addressees that failure in this respect could lead to disconnection of water supply under Section 10(h) of the WWO if supply can be disconnected outside the premises. Urgency shall refer to those cases that endanger life or property and water seepage cases in general should not be classified as cases of urgency. If disconnection cannot be effected without entering into the premises or Section 10(h) is not applicable, staff should consider applying for a warrant for entry into premises according to Section 12 of the WWO. The guideline on how to apply for a warrant is attached in **Appendix 1.6**.

Table 1 - Time allowed for consumers/agents’ follow up action in response to WSD’s notices

Scenario	Time allowed for consumer’s/ agent’s follow up action. Door lock letter or Notice demanding access for inspection
Urgent cases such as serious water leakage	3 days
Moderate water leakage	7 days
Non-urgent cases such as minor water leakage	14 days

- 1.4.5.4 After obtaining the warrant, the Engineer/Inspection or Chief Waterworks Inspector in charge should liaise with the HK Police and Fire Services Department of the Region for forced entry. The Engineer/Inspection or Chief Waterworks Inspector in charge shall write to the concerned occupiers and RC, informing them that a warrant for entry into the premises been obtained and WSD will enter the premises for inspection at any time.

2. Handling of Customer Complaints and Referrals

2.1 Water Quality

2.1.1 Site Work Instruction for Handling Customers' Complaints in Compliance with the Requirement of ISO 9001: 2015

2.1.1.1 WSD has implemented an Integrated Quality Management System (IQMS) in compliance with the requirements of ISO 9001:2015. The ISO documents, including the Integrated Quality Manual (IQM), Integrated Quality Procedural Manual (IQPM) and Customer Services Procedural Manual (CSPM), governing the works of Region(CS) in handling customers' complaints have been posted on WSD Intranet Homepage.

2.1.1.2 As an integral part of the WSD IQMS of ISO 9001:2015, Site Work Instruction for Handling Customers' Complaints is issued (in bilingual). Staff members of Region (CS) Inspection team and Works team should follow the Site Work Instruction (**Appendix 2.1**) in handling the respective complaints as stated in the CSPM.

2.1.2 Procedures on Following Up Case of Exceedance under Enhanced Water Quality Monitoring Programme

Background

2.1.2.1 Under the Enhanced Water Quality Monitoring Programme ("Enhanced Programme"), water samples will be randomly collected from consumers' drinking taps for testing five metals viz. lead, cadmium, chromium, nickel and copper that could be present in the internal plumbing systems and a total of about 670 water samples will be taken in the territory each year. If there is exceedance of the respective standards² of the five metal parameters in the 2-tier water samples³ collected from a consumer's drinking tap of a premises ("the affected premises"), WSc Division will form a team with Region (CS) to visit the affected premises and convey the testing result as well as necessary information such as health advice and mitigation measures etc. to the occupier and the RC concerned if possible. During the site visit, material check on pipes and fittings on site (inside premises if permitted by occupier and outside premises) will be conducted to verify the

² The Hong Kong Drinking Water Standards are available from the WSD's webpage at: <https://www.wsd.gov.hk/en/core-businesses/water-quality/my-drinking-water-quality/hong-kong-drinking-water-standards/index.html>

³ The 2-tier water samples include Random Daytime (RDT) and 30-Minute Stagnation (30MS) water samples. No flushing will be carried out before taking RDT samples whilst the plumbing system may or may not have been used by consumers before the taking of the samples. In taking the 30MS sample, the tap should first be flushed for 5 minutes and then stagnated for 30 minutes before the sample is taken.

initial preliminary assessment on whether the exceedance is isolated/suspected non-isolated case/uncertain case.

- 2.1.2.2 WSD will adopt a supportive approach by offering the participants of the Enhanced Programme a one-off free investigation into the cause and location of exceedance in the water samples of the concerned drinking water tap by WSD's term consultant ("preliminary investigation"). The participants will be notified of the investigation findings so as to facilitate them to arrange rectification. Alternatively, the RCs can choose to engage by themselves a qualified person (i.e. building services engineer, building surveyor or licensed plumber who has been included in the list of qualified person for the investigation maintained by WSD) for conducting the investigation work.
- 2.1.2.3 Moreover, in order to provide assistance to the needy groups of people, (i.e. the disabled, the elderly and people under the Comprehensive Social Security Assistance Scheme) if any, in the concerned domestic premises, WSD's social service team ("SST") will consider whether there is any imminent need of the needy groups of people. If yes, SST will offer them appropriate short-term mitigation (i.e. arrangement for installation of filter) and assistance for applying loans and hardship grant/subsidies for their long-term rectification. SST will also help liaise with owners/occupiers in "three-nil buildings"⁴ for rectification and seek assistance from relevant departments/local representatives (e.g. HAD and District Council Members) for coordinating further liaison if necessary and provide assistance / advice to them to facilitate their formation of owners' corporations.

Preparation Work, Joint Site Visit, Notification and Follow-up when Case of Exceedance is Found

2.1.2.4 For Individual Premises

- (a) When case of exceedance is found, WSc Division will prepare the notification letter and Regions (CS) will be notified (by email/phone) to provide support in conducting on-site material check on pipes and fittings. A copy of the notification letter will be provided to Regions (CS) for their preparation work (e.g. to arrange modification of the draft notification letters for issuance in case it is a non-isolated case of exceedance, to plan ahead for searching contact address of all other owners of the building if the concerned premises is located in a three-nil building, etc.). SE/Regions (CS) should assign promptly their CS staff to carry out a site visit on the same day when being notified of any non-compliant RDT water samples by WSc Division, to identify the possible existence of premises where water is (i) for public consumption (e.g. restaurants) or (ii) for consumption by more easily affected groups

⁴ "Three-nil buildings" means buildings without owners' corporations (OCs), residents' organisations or property management companies (PMCs).

(e.g. kindergartens, in case of lead exceedance) in the same building (i.e. public premises). If the existence of public premises is affirmative, the CS staff are required to obtain and keep proper record of the number and details (e.g. types of premises and addresses) of the public premises for reporting to SE/Region (CS) for subsequent advice to the concerned Senior Chemist for information. SE/Region (CS) should also assign their CS staff (preferably an AWI (CS) or above) to form a team with the Chemist from WSc Division to carry out a site visit to the affected premises on the following day to carry out the on-site material check.

- (b) For the joint site visit, the Regional CS staff assigned will assist to gain entry into the affected premises and introduce WSc Division for giving relevant explanation via prior appointment with the occupier by phone in that morning⁵. According to the directive from the Management subject to on-site observations, the Regional CS staff will carry out the material check for exposed pipework by non-destructive test such as quick in-situ tests (portable XRF analyzer; alternatively instant test swab for lead)⁶ for detection of the concerned metal composition, and should subsequently provide the Chemist and SE/Region (CS) the record of the test conducted for their information and keep proper record. A checklist for conducting material check as well as a record template are given in Appendix 2.2. Moreover, the Regional CS staff will provide the SST's contact information⁷ to the occupier (including those in public rental housing (PRH) estates under the HA) to facilitate his/her possible need to seek the SST's assistance. For those affected domestic premises in HA's PRH estates, the Regional CS staff should also inform the HA's representative⁸ of the concerned PRH estate of the completion of the site visit for the HA's follow-up actions.
- (c) The Regional CS staff should provide the relevant information including the copy of notification letters and information pack to the SST and also ask them to carry out a separate site visit to the affected domestic premises (except those in PRH estates under the HA) subsequent to the joint site visit as mentioned in section 2.1.2.4(a) above. The SST will then take necessary follow-up action for the needy groups of people in the affected premises, if any.
- (d) Regions (CS) should follow procedures (D)(6) in **Appendix 2.3** (Extracted from "*Steps involved in the Enhanced Water Quality Monitoring Programme*")⁹ during

⁵ In case the occupier refuses to allow a site visit and requests explanation of test result on phone, the Chemist should be referred to make a phone call to explain the case to the occupier.

⁶ Both portable XRF analyzer and instant test swab for lead should be equipped in the joint site visit.

⁷ The information of the SST concerned is available in the Intranet of Technical Support Division. Name card of the SST can be provided when available.

⁸ The contact of the HA's representative of the concerned PRH estate is to be given by WSc Division.

⁹ Appendix 2.3 refers to the version of the document concerned as at the issuance date of this instruction. The latest version of the document / materials concerned should be followed, if available. Please refer to "Network Drive for Sharing Materials of Enhanced Programme" under this instruction in TS Division's intranet.

the notification and follow-up stage. If the occupier cannot be reached by phone/visit on the day of notification, Regional CS staff should keep attempting to make appointment with the occupier for arranging the joint site visit until the occupier can be contacted.

2.1.2.5 For Buildings with Possibility of Exceedance in Other Premises (i.e. Suspected Non-isolated Case)

Upon notification from WSc Division that a suspected non-isolated case of exceedance in a building is revealed after their assessment, apart from attending the joint site visit with WSc Division, the Region (CS) shall be responsible for notifying the relevant parties responsible for maintaining and managing the building such as PMCs, OCs etc. as appropriate of the result of investigation and for issuing notification letters and information pack, which are prepared by WSc Division, to the relevant parties. Region (CS) shall follow procedures (E) in **Appendix 2.3** for notification and follow-up. The number and details of the public premises as obtained in section 2.1.2.4(a) above should be checked with the responsible parties concerned and the contact point of the responsible parties concerned should be obtained for future communication.

If suspected non-isolated case of exceedance is identified in a three-nil building, apart from attending the joint site visit with WSc Division, Region (CS) shall also issue the concerned notification letters and information pack to all occupiers and premises owners¹⁰ (via Land Registry as far as practicable) of the building. The Regional CS staff shall ask the SST to promptly carry out site visits to other premises in the three-nil building concerned in order to identify the existence of any needy groups of people in the building and to assess any imminent need of those people and take follow up action. SST will also liaise with owners/occupiers for rectification and seek assistance from HAD and DC members for coordinating further liaisons if necessary.

Preliminary Investigation

- 2.1.2.6 Upon receipt of the concerned RC's written consent during the site visit in Section 2.1.2.4(a) or subsequent return of reply slip¹¹ (see Reply Slip for RC to be attached to Letter 2A/2B in **Appendix 2.4** (Extracted from "*Communication Kit for Enhanced Water Quality Monitoring Programme*"¹²)) for opting WSD to carry out the preliminary investigation, provided that no objection to carrying out the investigation raised by

¹⁰ The address of the owner of the affected premises has already been obtained by WSc Division.

¹¹ Even the RC replies late on his/her wish for WSD's consultant to investigate, WSD will adopt a supportive approach and will still arrange the preliminary investigation.

¹² **Appendix 2.4** refers to the version of the document concerned as at the issuance date of this instruction. The latest version of the document/materials concerned should be followed, if available. Please refer to "Network Drive for Sharing Materials of Enhanced Programme" under this instruction in TS Division's intranet.

occupier/premises owner is received (e.g. by writing, phone etc.) and access to the premises is given by the occupier, SE/Region (CS) shall arrange, with assistance from E/Region (CS) Inspection (E/Region (CS)I), to instruct the term consultant (by email followed by letter) in writing issued by CE/Region (“a task order”) to carry out the preliminary investigation promptly, under the consultancy agreement, namely Consultancy Service for Preliminary Investigation of Excess Metal Content Found in Drinking Water¹³.

- 2.1.2.7 SE/Region (CS) shall administer the task order issued and closely monitor the progress of the preliminary investigation carried out by the term consultant with a view to coming up with the investigation findings as soon as possible¹⁴. Region (CS) shall follow the procedures (D)(iii)(7) – (12) in **Appendix 2.3** and shall be responsible for notifying the participants, relevant parties of the result of investigation and provide them the necessary information as well as the relevant bureau/departments (B/Ds) if applicable (by email and phone). Please refer to Letter 3 and 4A in **Appendix 2.4** for the letter templates for notification of investigation findings to the participants and to relevant parties responsible for maintaining and managing the building such as PMCs, OCs etc. as appropriate respectively.
- 2.1.2.8 In case a non-isolated case is identified in a three-nil building according to the findings of the preliminary investigation, the Regional CS staff shall ask the SST to promptly carry out a visit to the three-nil building concerned for the SST to identify the existence of needy groups of people in other premises in the building and to assess any imminent need of those people and take follow up action¹⁵. SST will also liaise with owners/occupiers for rectification and seek assistance from HAD and DC members for coordinating further liaisons if necessary. The notification of investigation findings shall be made to all occupiers and premises owners (as far as practicable) of the building instead (Please refer to Letter 4B in **Appendix 2.4** for the letter template).

Subsequent Follow-up Action

- 2.1.2.9 SE/Region (CS) shall take subsequent follow-up action¹⁶ for those cases of exceedance including the provision of advice on the engagement of qualified consultant/person to carry out investigation, monitoring the implementation of preventive measures and progress of investigation and rectification until its completion, according to the procedures

¹³ The consultancy documents concerned are available in the Intranet of Technical Support Division.

¹⁴ SE/Region (CS) may consider assigning the tasks to Engineer/Region (CS) Inspection (E/Region (CS)I) as appropriate.

¹⁵ The SST should have already visited the affected premises before the completion of preliminary investigation. Unless it is confirmed to be a non-isolated case, the SST should not visit other premises in the building.

¹⁶ SE/Region (CS) may consider assigning the tasks to E/Region (CS)I as appropriate.

(F)¹⁷ in **Appendix 2.3** for suspected non-isolated case and the procedures (F)(i) and (ii) in **Appendix 2.3** only for isolated case respectively.

2.1.2.10 After WSD has been notified by PMCs/OCs of the findings of their detailed investigation, the Regions (CS) shall notify the registered agent and consumers of the findings. Please refer to the letter template Letter 5A/5B in **Appendix 2.4**.

2.1.2.11 A flowchart illustrating the work flow is given in **Appendix 2.5**.

2.1.3 Standard Letters for Replying to Complaints of Discoloured Water

2.1.3.1 Subsequent to attending complaints of discoloured water received from the consumers with water samples taken for analysis, staff are expected to advise the complainant the result of their investigation in writing. The specimen of the standard reply in both English and Chinese in **Appendix 2.6** shall be used. The test results of water samples should be sent to the complainant with the standard letter.

2.1.4 Record Form for Water Quality Related Inspection

2.1.4.1 For recording inspection findings on the aspects of identification of improper water installation and unauthorized alteration/repair/extension (e.g. unauthorized installation of filters or illegal cross connection) during conducting water quality related inspections, the record form in **Appendix 2.7** is established for such purpose. Region CS (Inspection) team shall complete the record form upon completion of the inspection and upload the completed record form to the relevant case ID of CCBS as soon as possible.

2.1.5 Statistics for WSD Quarterly Report on Water Quality Complaints

2.1.5.1 As the Department is often required to quote statistics about the complaints on water quality in answering public enquiries, CE/Regions are required to submit monthly statistics on water quality complaints to SE/PR in the standard format given below :-

¹⁷ In case of suspected non-isolated case, both procedures (F)(i)-(ii) for the concerned premises found with exceedance and procedures (F)(iii)-(iv) for the same building with possibility of exceedance in other premise should be followed respectively.

Type \ Month	Month					
	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun
A. Water Quality Complaints With Samples Taken :						
Dirty or Discoloured						
Taste or Odour						
Others						
Sub-total:						
B. Water Quality Complaints With No Sample Taken :						
Dirty or Discoloured						
Taste or Odour						
Others						
Sub-total:						
C. Total Water Quality Complaints (A+B)						

2.1.6 Guidelines in Handling Widespread Water Quality Incidents by CS Staff

Background

- 2.1.6.1 For widespread water supply incidents, the WSD should normally have issued press releases to make the incidents known to the public extensively. CS staff are required to observe the guidelines detailed in the following subsections when handling widespread water quality incidents.

Guidelines

- 2.1.6.2 When a widespread water quality incident has occurred, the CTEC will inevitably receive a large number of telephone enquiries/complaints from those customers who have been affected by the incident. CTEC staff shall follow the “Guideline in Handling Widespread Water Quality Incidents by CTEC” in **Appendix 2.8**.
- 2.1.6.3 (a) When PRU and GR receive water quality complaints through 1823 and email respectively, they will forward the case to Regions with copies to CTEC. When Regions receive water quality complaints through other channels (such as letters, emails, direct phone calls etc.), they should refer the case details (such as the details of complaint, the name of the complainants, the channel of lodging complaint, the name of reporting officer, etc.) to CTEC through telephone no. 2519 3360 or email immediately.

- 2.1.6.4 Experience tells that many customers calling to raise enquiries/complaints in regard to the widespread water quality incident will require the CTEC staff who handle their calls to provide, amongst other requests, the cause of the incident as well as advice whether the discoloured water coming out from the taps in their premises will affect health if consumed. The CTEC officer in-charge on duty must prepare unified answers and post them on the wall-board for all CTEC staff, including frontline CSOs, for reference when responding to such questions raised by callers. These unified answers should in general be prepared basing on the WSD's official statement/line-to-take issued by SE/PR for that particular incident. Before that official line-to-take/statement from SE/PR has become available, all CTEC staff should only tell callers, basing on advices prepared by the officer in-charge on duty posted on the wall-board, that:
- (a) On the onset of a water quality incident, the cause has not yet been ascertained as investigation by our site maintenance colleagues is still in progress. It may originate from the WSD's system or the inside services of the premises concerned. However, any wrong accusations as suggested by the caller, in particular those from the press, has to be denied right away in the first instance. Any less-than-firm responses such as "case still under investigation", "no comment to your guess", etc. or speaking with hesitation may possibly be taken as our agreement to his/her wild guess;
 - (b) The MO can arrange cleansing of the building's water tanks while individual consumers can allow their tap water running for a few minutes to let it return clear as discoloration usually lasts for a short period of time. Besides, individual units may still receive discoloured water for a short while after the WSD's system and/or the building's water tanks have been thoroughly cleaned up, as some discoloured water may have entered their inside pipe systems. Flushing the taps in the units will usually resolve the problem; and
 - (c) The existence of small amount of fine deposits in tap water will usually not affect health if consumed. Slightly discoloured water will also not be detrimental to health. The WSD will collect water samples from premises affected to ascertain that water supplied to them is safe to consume, if and when necessary.
- 2.1.6.5 The callers should also be informed of the locations of TPS provided by the WSD (if available). They should be soothed that even though water with slight quality problem is safe to use, they can obtain normal good-quality TPS from water wagons, water tanks and/or standpipes provided by the WSD, if they find more comfortable in doing so. They should also be invited to visit the WSD homepage for detailed information on the types and locations of TPS the WSD has arranged for the incident.

- 2.1.6.6 For widespread water quality incidents, the CTEC should prepare pre-recorded announcements for the incidents, and post them at the announcement position right after the language selection menu in the Interactive Voice Responding System (IVRS) of the CTEC. In addition, for such incidents with-TPS being provided, raising of WSMS-ESD cases for the incidents on the WSD Homepage should be done, with the due clarification made in the "Remarks" cell that these are water quality cases.
- 2.1.6.7 For widespread water quality incidents, the Region (CS) concerned should, on receiving “immediate to do” orders (ITDs) from the CTEC, form special task teams to
- (a) Visit premises affected as necessary to check their inside services and give advices to consumers directly on-site; and liaise with the Management Office to make sure that appropriate actions (e.g. close outlet valves of the sump tanks/roof tanks, flushing, tank cleansing, etc.) have been taken by them to mitigate the water quality problems. The Guidelines on Actions to be taken by Management Offices in the Event of Water Quality Incidents are given in **Appendix 2.9**.
 - (b) Collect water samples from premises and/or flush their meters, if necessary (the WSc Division also be informed of these widespread water quality incidents promptly, in order that they can take follow-up action as and when necessary).
- 2.1.6.8 The Region (CS) should also mobilise staff to man water wagons deployed to provide TPS to the area affected, if the Region (Distribution) / (Headworks) concerned has determined that such kind of TPS is to be provided for the incident.
- 2.1.6.9 Staff in the Region (CS) should also adopt the same ways as covered in Subsection 2.1.6.4 and Subsection 2.1.6.5 above when responding to water quality related enquiries/complaints from customers when they attend such incidents on site.

2.1.7 Procedures for Monitoring Water Quality of New Housing Estates *[New section incorporated in January 2023 version]*

Background

- 2.1.7.1 We have received fresh water quality complaints from residents of some new housing estates. It has been observed that at the initial stage of the resident intake, the low water demand in the housing estate would lead to slow flow velocity in its inside service and stagnant water at water tanks of the building blocks causing sediments to settle at the inside service pipe invert (particularly for those estates with long length of buried communal

pipes) and water tanks. These sediments are usually non-bitumen deposits; and their contents are mainly lime and traces of minerals remained in the treated water after the water treatment process. With the resident intake builds up with time and water consumption increases, the sediments may be stirred up by the variation of demand/flow of water resulted in observably higher turbidity which will be queried by residents as water quality problem. The situation should be greatly improved upon completion of resident intake and water consumption largely steady. Thus, the main objective of this guideline is to set out the necessary precautionary measures during the early stage of resident intake in new housing developments with a view to avoiding the water quality complaints.

Guidelines

- 2.1.7.2 Upon completion of water supply application cases for new housing estate with two or more blocks of building, the responsible Region(CS)Application Team should forward a copy of the Form WWO46 Pt.V(b) to Region(CS) Inspection Team. The Regions(CS) Inspection Team should keep and update regularly a summary of new housing estates (**Annex 1 of Appendix 2.10**) of the Region.
- 2.1.7.3 Region(CS)Inspection Team should monitor the progress of occupation of new housing estates. A letter should be issued to the Registered Agent of the housing estate within 2 months from the date of issue of WWO46 Pt.V(b) to obtain the name and address of the management office for the estate and the anticipated date of occupation. If no feedback is received within one month, Region(CS)Inspection Team should check the record of water consumption as registered by the Master Meter of the housing development as well as the daily consumption pattern in INMS to assess if there has been resident intake for the estate. In case the data from INMS is not available, alternative means such as liaison with the Housing Department for public housing estate, site visit, search of press reports, etc. should be conducted to ascertain the situation. Region(CS) Inspection Team should then arrange a site inspection to these housing estates within 2 weeks after occupation date, subject to the Registered Agent (RA) / management office's arrangement, to assess the risk of water stagnation in inside service. The E/Region(CS)Inspection should check the summary quarterly in January, April, July and October to determine necessary follow up actions and subsequently submit it to SE/Regions(CS) for monitoring.
- 2.1.7.4 While the water tanks of inside service should normally be flushed and cleaned not more than three-month intervals, for new housing development with initial stage of resident intake, the RA/management office should be advised to carry out more frequent inspections to their water tanks (e.g. every two weeks or monthly, subject to the condition found). If sediments are observed in the water tank, flushing to the tank should be carried out by the RA / management offices. In addition, during and after the site inspection, Region(CS) Inspection Team should liaise with and provide technical support to the RA /

management offices of the housing estates for (i) proper and more frequent flushing of respective water tanks of building blocks and the inside service, particularly where long length of communal pipes are involved, with a view to removing sediments which might have settled and accumulated due to the slow flow in the pipes; and (ii) adjustment to a lower water level for switch off pump to shorten the retention time of water at storage tanks and thus stagnant water in the tanks so as to increase the cycles of water usage in the water tanks. During the site inspection, copy of the latest version of leaflet “Water Use Tips” (**Annex 2 of Appendix 2.10**) should be provided to the management office for display at the prominent location and distribution to residents. To provide a more detailed guideline to the Management Office (MO) on the inspection and flushing of inside service, a set of leaflet (**Annex 3 of Appendix 2.10**) is prepared for distribution along with ‘Water Use Tips’. This includes a table for the MO with recommendations on the inspection and flushing frequency of water tanks and inside service, and advice on the flushing of communal pipes during periods with different occupation rates.

[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

- 2.1.7.5 If bituminous black particles were observed in the storage tank, Region(CS)Inspection Team should inform Region(Distribution) O&M Team to take necessary follow up actions pursuant to Appendix 1.3.1B of S&DB Handbook (Distribution). In case the new housing estate is located at a dead end of the government supply network, Region(Distribution) O&M Team should arrange regular flushing of the related government water mains and take water samples at nearby hydrants for water quality checking.

2.2 Leakage and Seepage

2.2.1 Maintenance Responsibilities of Water Authority / Agent / Consumers

- 2.2.1.1 The maintenance responsibilities of communal service / inside service on government / private lands are illustrated in **Appendix 2.11**.
- 2.2.1.2 Pursuant to Section 17(2)(b) of the WWO, the cost of maintaining, altering, repairing or removing any part of a fire service or inside service which is on land held by the Government shall be borne by the Water Authority.

2.2.2 Enhanced Procedures for Handling Cases of Private Water Main Leakage

Identification of the Responsible Party and Investigation of the Leakage

- 2.2.2.1 Upon receipt of a notification on an alleged private water main leakage incident, Region (CS) Inspection Team should collect facts and evidence to establish a prima facie case for

the alleged private water main leakage as well as to identify the party (consumer/agent) responsible for maintaining the private water main. Possible methods that can be employed include visual inspection, conduction of a meter flow test, closure of valves, computation of the discrepancy ratio¹⁸ and checking of minimum night flow¹⁹ by means of the bulk meter or master meter, if any.

- 2.2.2.2 If leakage is suspected to come from a section of buried private water main within a private lot, it is not easy to confirm where the leak is located. This is especially difficult when the leakage is suspected to come from a private water main network with more than one responsible party. Under these circumstances, more detailed investigation as outlined in the ensuing subsections is required.
- 2.2.2.3 If the detailed investigation involves valve operation or excavation to be carried out within a private lot, prompt action should be taken to obtain consent from the relevant occupier(s)/consumer(s)/agent(s) to enable the investigation works to be carried out at the earliest possible time. If the entry into a private lot for investigation is refused or the premises are unoccupied, Region (CS) Inspection Team should, after trying all practicable means, consider obtaining a warrant under Section 12 of WWO for gaining entry into the private lot for the detailed investigation.
- 2.2.2.4 If the detailed investigation involves carrying out valve operation on government main or excavation to locate the leak within a private lot, Region (CS) Inspection Team should seek support from Region (Distribution) Team. Region (CS) Inspection Team should be responsible for obtaining the consent from the relevant occupier(s)/consumer(s)/agent(s) or a warrant for the Region (Distribution) Team to carry out excavation (in addition to the valve operation on government main) and subsequent reinstatement within the private lot.

Handling of Serious Leakage / Consequence Cases

- 2.2.2.5 During the investigation, if the leakage and/or its consequence is considered serious, such as wasting a lot of water, affecting the stability of slope/road, causing flooding to properties or risk to lives etc., immediate suspension under Section 9 of WWO or disconnection under Section 10 of WWO of the water supply should be carried out to conserve water and/or protect lives and properties²⁰. Suspension of water supply is normally effected for leakage in communal pipes by closing the control valve in government main while disconnection of water supply is normally effected for leakage in inside service of individual consumer(s) by physical disconnection such as removal of

¹⁸ Discrepancy ratio is the ratio of the consumption recorded by the bulk meter or master meter (which records the amount of water supplied to the whole premises) to the aggregate water consumptions recorded by all individual consumer meters within the premises.

¹⁹ Minimum night flow is the lowest water flow rate measured in the bulk meter or master meter at night time.

²⁰ See **Appendix 2.14** for examples of serious leakage that requires immediate suspension or disconnection of water supply.

water meter.

- 2.2.2.6 After suspension or disconnection of water supply, the affected consumer(s) should be notified as far as possible stating the reason for suspension or disconnection of water supply and requested to complete the repair works as soon as possible for the restoration of water supply. Temporary fresh water supply should be considered when the installation of temporary standpipes at fire hydrants is feasible.

Handling of Leakage of Private Water Mains

2.2.2.7 Issue of Repair Notice (Form WWO 48)

- (a) When the prima facie case for the leakage at the private water main is established and the responsible party is identified, repair notice (Form WWO 48) should be issued to the responsible party as soon as practicable and preferably within 2 working days. The authority for signing the repair notice is specified in **Appendix 2.12**. In the repair notice, the engineer/inspector should specify a reasonable time limit for the responsible party to complete the repair works to the leaking private water main, taking into account the factors including but not limited to the following:
- (i) Seriousness of the leakage in terms of loss of water;
 - (ii) Consequence of leakage;
 - (iii) Difficulty of repair works; and
 - (iv) Number of consumers affected if it is envisaged that they may have to coordinate among themselves for the repair works.
- (b) To assist the engineer/inspector to determine the time limit for the responsible party to complete the repair works, leakage cases are classified into three priorities, namely ‘**high**’, ‘**medium**’ and ‘**low**’, as explained in the **Appendix 2.13** and **Appendix 2.14**. It should be noted that the time limit set out in Table C of **Appendix 2.13** serves as a general guideline. Special circumstances may justify a shorter/longer time limit for the repair works. If in doubt, the engineer/inspector should seek steer from his supervising officer.
- (c) In order to minimize the loss of water before completion of the repair works, Region (CS) staff should try to reduce the water flow in the leaking private water main as far as practicable, by throttling the control valve in the government main and/or temporarily clamping the leak in the private water main, with the assistance from Region (Distribution) Team if necessary.

Assistance from District Office (DO)

- 2.2.2.8 For cases where a large number of consumers are affected, it is anticipated that there will be difficulty for the individual consumers to coordinate among themselves for the repair works. In such cases, the note below should be included in the repair notice to remind the consumers to seek assistance from the appropriate DO as needed. The repair notice should also be copied to the relevant DO for information.

(English): *You may approach the XX District Office for assistance if you and other consumers of the building wish to form an owners'/residents' organization to follow up the repair or other works detailed above.*

(中文): *如您擬與大廈其他用戶成立業主／居民組織以便跟進上述的維修或工程，可考慮向XX 民政事務處尋求協助。*

Extension of Time (EOT) to Complete the Repair Works

- 2.2.2.9 Difficulties may be encountered by the responsible party in carrying out the repair works to the leaking private water main in view of the amount of time required for coordination among themselves for the repair works or resolving technical problem in the repair works itself. When the responsible party requires a longer time for the repair works, EOT may be considered provided that a written request is submitted to WSD stating the grounds for EOT to complete the repair works. The approving officer should carefully consider the grounds of the EOT request. Some reasons, such as those listed below, are merely excuses for delaying the repair works and should not be accepted:
- (a) The building is about to be redeveloped.
 - (b) The tenancy agreement will expire soon. The repair works will be carried out after the tenant has moved out.
 - (c) The repair works will be carried out next year in conjunction with the major renovation of the entire building.
- 2.2.2.10 EOT should only be granted under special circumstances provided that full justification is given by the responsible party, together with solid evidence showing their willingness and readiness to complete the repair works within reasonable time. Granting of EOT should be given by an officer of at least one grade/rank higher than the officer who signed the repair notice in accordance with the respective approving authorities for EOT as listed in **Appendix 2.12**.

Issue of Disconnection Notice (Form WWO 47)

- 2.2.2.11 If the responsible party fails to complete the repair works within the time limit specified in the repair notice or the extended time when the EOT is approved, Region (CS) staff should promptly issue a disconnection notice²¹ (Form WWO 47) to the responsible party and arrange to disconnect the water supply to the concerned premises under Section 11(1) and 10(e) of WWO as soon as practicable. Reference can be made to DI No. 919 for the procedures of disconnection. After disconnection of water supply, the affected consumer(s) should be notified as far as possible stating the reason for suspension or disconnection of water supply. Temporary fresh water supply should be considered when installation of temporary standpipes at fire hydrants is feasible.

Repair Works by WSD and Cost Recovery

- 2.2.2.12 Section 7 of WWO stipulates that the maintenance responsibility of an inside service (including communal service) is borne by the RC/RA and Section 10(e) of WWO stipulates that any failure to carry out repairs or other works specified in the repair notice may result in disconnection of water supply.
- 2.2.2.13 Notwithstanding the above, WSD may carry out the repairs for the responsible party under two circumstances as stipulated in Section 17(3) and 17(4) of WWO:

“S17(3): The Water Authority may alter or repair a fire service or inside service at the request of a consumer, or a communal service at the request of an agent, and the cost thereof shall, subject to subsection (2)(b), be payable by the person at whose request such alteration or repair is carried out.

S17(4): If a consumer or agent, on receipt of a notice under section 16, fails to carry out the repairs or other works specified in the notice, the Water Authority may carry out the repairs or other works and the cost thereof shall be payable by the consumer or agent.”

- 2.2.2.14 While the responsible party has the responsibility under Section 7 of WWO to carry out the repair works to the leaking private water main, technical advice and list of LPs may be provided to the responsible party to facilitate them to carry out the repair works. Moreover, subject to the satisfaction of all of the following conditions, the SE/Region (CS) may review if it is justified for WSD to step in to carry out the repair works to the leaking

²¹ Pursuant to Section 2.9.1, subsequent to the issue of a Form WWO 48, re-inspection should be conducted within 5 working days after the due date specified in the repair notice, or the extended time when the EOT is approved. For cases where the repair works have not been completed, Form WWO 47 should be issued within 3 working days after the re-inspection according to DI No. 919.

private water main:

- (a) the responsible party has great difficulty in coordinating the repair works;
- (b) the number of consumers affected due to suspension or disconnection of water supply is large; and
- (c) the responsible party has signed WWO 1155 to bear the repair cost (for cases under S17(3)).

2.2.2.15 If WSD is to step in to carry out the repair works to the leaking private water main, SE/Region(CS) should request the SE/Region(Distribution) to carry out the repair works. Moreover, SE/Region(CS) should be responsible for the coordination of the repair works and the subsequent recovery of the cost of the repair works.

2.2.2.16 Upon completion of the repair works to the leaking private water main, Region (Distribution) Team should finalize the account of the repair works as soon as possible and forward the finalized account to E/Region(CS)I. E/Region(CS)I should prepare a list of the responsible parties, their addresses, the amount of repair cost and supervision charge that should be charged to each party, and inform TA/F to issue demand notes to recover the cost from the parties.

Monitoring Mechanism

2.2.2.17 Region (CS) Inspection Team should keep a register of all private water main leakage cases and keep track of their progress to ensure timely actions are taken. These cases should be recorded in the register in **Appendix 1.1**. E/Region(CS)I should monitor the progress of each of these cases and bring up any difficult and problematic cases to SE/Region(CS) for steer in a timely manner.

[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

2.2.2.18 CE/Region should review the overall progress in the handling of private water main leakage cases with SE/Region(CS) on a monthly basis and determine appropriate actions to be taken to prevent long outstanding and unresolved cases. Cases with great difficulties should be brought up to AD/Urban or AD/NT for steer.

2.2.3 Procedures for Handling Repair of Private Mains Laid on Government Lands

2.2.3.1 While most of the inside service and fire service, i.e. private mains not owned and maintained by the WA for the purpose of a supply, are laid on private lands, some of them are laid on Government lands. For the purpose of this section, Government lands refer to

unleased Government lands and public roads but not lands allocated to other Government departments. RA or RC are responsible for the maintenance of these private mains including both laid on private lands and Government lands. Pursuant to Section 17(3) and 17(2)(b) of the WWO, the WA may carry out alteration or repair works of private mains at the request of the RA or RC and the costs of such works shall be borne by the WA if they are located on Government lands. Therefore, Regions **shall not recover** any costs from the RA/RC/occupiers for the alteration or repair works of their private mains laid on Government lands.

- 2.2.3.2 Regional staff shall follow the procedures below in addition to those stipulated in the “Guidance Notes on Handling of Main Bursts and Emergency Maintenance of Water Mains” when handling repair works of private mains laid on Government lands.

Procedures

- 2.2.3.3 The party who first attends a fault complaint of private mains (i.e. WS/Region of turn-cock gang or MSSET team, etc.) shall ascertain, in consultation with Regional maintenance SWI/AWI or Duty Officer if necessary, the land status of the subject water mains based on available information and records (including mains record plans, land lot/status plans, etc.).
- 2.2.3.4 If the case is related to defects of private mains laid on private lands, the procedures stated in Section 2.2.2 shall be followed.
- 2.2.3.5 If the case is related to main burst/leak of private mains laid on Government lands, the WS/Region of turn-cock gang or MSSET team shall isolate the damaged/burst pipe and provide the following standard information to CTEC in Chinese for reporting the water suspension.

[一段位處政府土地，直徑_____毫米供水給上述處所的私人*食水/鹹水/消防喉管出現破損/爆裂。為避免*對財物造成損失/對道路交通造成影響及浪費用水，水務署已於_____ (日期及時間) 暫停上述處所的*食水/沖廁水/消防用水供水。]

- 2.2.3.6 At the same time, the WS/Region of turn-cock gang or MSSET team shall inform the CS/Inspection Team, who shall follow the procedures below:

(a) For premises with management office (MO) or owner’s corporation (OC)

- (i) Advise the MO/OC of the concerned premises that the damaged/burst pipe is

a private main located on Government lands. Although the WA does not bear the maintenance responsibilities of their private mains according to the WWO, WA will repair the damaged/burst pipe due to urgency at the request of the MO/OC. However, the repaired damaged/burst pipe will still be their private main and the MO/OC should remain to be responsible for its future maintenance.

- (ii) Request the representative of the MO/OC to sign the consent form and inform the occupiers/residents of the premises by posting a notice in the form of **Appendix 2.15** at conspicuous location within the premises stating that WA would carry out repair works for the inside service/fire service of the premises at the request of the MO/OC. A copy of the notice shall be provided to CS/Inspection Team for record purpose. If the MO/OC refuses to inform the residents, the CS/Inspection team shall post a notice in the form of **Appendix 2.16** at public locations in close proximity of the entrances of the premises.

(b) For premises without management office (MO) or owner's corporation (OC)

- (i) In case that no MO / OC or no responsible agents /consumers can be identified for the premises being affected, WA shall repair the faults of the inside service/fire service located on Government lands.
- (ii) The CS/Inspection Team shall inform the occupiers/residents of the premises by posting a notice at a public location in close proximity to the entrance of the premises in the form of **Appendix 2.15** signed by the Inspector of the CS/Inspection Team.

2.2.3.7 The turn-cock or MSSET team shall proceed with the repair works and provide the following additional standard information to CTEC.

[(*因應管理公司/業主立案法團的要求，)水務署將協助為該位處政府土地的私人水管進行緊急修理工程。初步預計，緊急修理工程可望於____月____日____午____時____分完成。]

2.2.3.8 Upon completion of the urgent repair works, the CS/Inspection Team shall send a letter in the format given in **Appendix 2.17** to the concerned RA/RC of the premises to inform them that the repair works have been completed and they shall continue to be responsible for the maintenance of the concerned water mains.

2.2.4 Procedures for Handling Complaints on Defective Private Mains

- 2.2.4.1 Private main is owned and maintained by private parties. It is laid either exposed or buried, mostly in private land but for some exceptions also in government land. There is no visual demarcation on such private main to facilitate the public to differentiate it from a WSD watermain. Therefore, the public has quite often mistaken the former as the latter and may report any defect found in such main to WSD for action. Irrespective of whether a watermain is maintained by a private party or WSD, a member of the public who reports a defect of a watermain to WSD expects that WSD will rectify or demand the party responsible for its maintenance to rectify the defect.
- 2.2.4.2 When CTEC receives a report on a defective private main causing flooding or serious nuisance, or a report on defect in WSD watermain, CTEC will issue an ITD to RCC(D) or Duty Officer after office hours and the case will be attended by MSSET or Distribution Emergency / standby gang. However, if the report case is about defects in private main without causing flooding or serious nuisance, CTEC will issue an ITD to RCC (CS) or CS Standby gang after office hours and the case will be attended by MSSET or CS Works Team / standby gang instead.
- 2.2.4.3 For cases where ITD(CS) are issued to Region(CS) at the beginning, MSSET or CS Works Team /standby gang must assess whether immediate isolation of the private main and arrangement of temporary water supply are needed. If needed, they should seek confirmation from supervisor during office hours or CTEC after office hours. If immediate isolation is not necessary, CS Works Team should refer the ITD(CS) to the CS Inspection Team to conduct inspection. After site inspection, the CS Inspection Team should inform the complainant of the action to be taken by WSD in response to the complaint. The CS Inspection Team should also feedback the same to CTEC.
- 2.2.4.4 For cases where ITD(D) are issued involving alleged WSD watermain which is subsequently confirmed on site as a private one, MSSET or Distribution emergency/standby gang must assess whether immediate isolation of the private main and arrangement of temporary water supply are needed. If it is needed, they should seek confirmation from the supervisor during office hours or the Duty Officer after office hours. If immediate isolation is not necessary, MSSET or Distribution emergency/standby gang should immediately refer the case to the CS Works Team and then telephone CTEC to close the ITD(D) with remarks stating clearly why such main is regarded as private. Then, CTEC should issue a new ITD(CS), with cross-reference to the ITD(D), to the CS Works Team who should refer to the CS Inspection Team for inspection. After site inspection, the CS Inspection Team should inform the complainant of the action to be action by WSD in response to the complaint. The CS Inspection Team should also

feedback the same to CTEC.

- 2.2.4.5 For all complaints about defective private mains coming from various channels, the complainant may be interested to be kept informed of the outcome. In this circumstance, upon the request through CTEC, Region(CS) staff should attempt to keep the complainant posted of the final development.

2.2.5 Enquiry from Consumers on Record of Private Water Distribution System Inside Building Lots

- 2.2.5.1 For the Maintenance of Buried Services Affecting Slopes (MOBSAS), CEDD has issued an “Advisory Note on Inspection & Maintenance of Buried Drainage & Water Services Affecting Slopes/Walls” to the property owners and the building management offices for them to take necessary actions in maintaining the buried services inside the building lots. A copy of the Advisory Note can be found in CEDD’s internet homepage via the link:
https://www.cedd.gov.hk/eng/publications/geo/leaflets-and-brochures/leaf_andrain/index.html
- 2.2.5.2 It is one of the advices given in the Note that property owners and building managers should identify and locate all the water-carrying services affecting slopes or retaining walls for planning an inspection programme. In so doing, the property owners and building managers may seek assistance from the relevant government departments in respect of records of private drains, public drains and water mains (both private and government). WSD has been nominated to assist in locating the water main records and CTEC (telephone number: 2824 5000) is the contact point of WSD.
- 2.2.5.3 Upon receiving enquiries of the kind, CTEC is to note down the particulars of the request and advise the enquirer that his enquiry will be referred to our Region to handle and they will contact him later. CTEC should then refer the case to the relevant SE/Region(CS) immediately for follow-up action including checking the records and making contact with the enquirer.

2.2.6 Repair Work to Inside Service / Communal Service in Public Housing Estates

- 2.2.6.1 In order to promote a better image of WSD and to avoid unnecessary delay in the resumption of water supply to a large number of consumers residing in the public housing estates after a breakdown of the internal water supply system has occurred, Region (CS) staff are required to positively involve themselves in the monitoring of the repair work

although the responsibility for carrying out such work is known to be that of the Housing Department (HD).

- 2.2.6.2 Region (CS) staff should closely liaise with the housing manager in monitoring the repair work to the defective internal main/inside service in the public housing estates. If necessary, assistance should be offered to HD as far as possible to facilitate early completion of the repair work.

2.2.7 Enhanced Procedures of Handling Complaints of Water Seepage in Buildings

- 2.2.7.1 This Section promulgates enhanced procedures of the WSD in handling complaints of water seepage in buildings (water seepage complaints) in collaboration with the JO of BD and FEHD.

Background

- 2.2.7.2 BD and FEHD set up the JO in December 2004 to handle water seepage complaints initially as a pilot scheme in Sham Shui Po for 6 months, which was extended to cover the whole territory in July 2006. The JO is to provide a “one-stop shop” service for handling water seepage complaints through the exercising of power under the Public Health and Municipal Services Ordinance (HK Law Cap. 132) (PHMSO) and the Buildings Ordinance (HK Law Cap. 123).

Procedures for Handling Water Seepage Complaints

2.2.7.3 Water Seepage Complaints Referred to WSD from JO

- (a) Upon receipt of the JO’s referral of a water seepage complaint, WI/CS(Inspection) should check the JO’s report within 3 working days to ascertain whether there is any of the following conclusive evidence of waste of water:-
- (i) visible leak(s) from water supply pipes; or
 - (ii) positive result from a 30-minute water meter flow check (i.e. the water meter records movement with its register in a 30-minute period though there has been no water consumption in the premises under complaint); or
 - (iii) positive RPT result with observable water dripping i.e. there is a clear indication in the RPT report or JO’s memo that the water dripping is caused by water supply pipe leakage.

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

- (b) If affirmative, Region(CS)(I) staff should contact the complainant to check the updated seepage condition. If it is confirmed that the seepage has ceased,

Region(CS)(I) staff should record in the CCBS that the case has been closed. E/Region(CS)(I) should make a reply to the complainant. A sample reply to the complainant, with a copy to the JO, is at **Appendix 2.18**. If it is confirmed that the seepage persists, Regions (CS) should issue a repair notice with a time limit for completing the repair works to the responsible consumer (RC / RA of the premises under complaint) within 2 working days as far as practicable for cases with a conclusion of positive meter flow check or positive RPT test, provided that no ambiguity or discrepancy found. The repair notice should mention :-

- (i) the responsible consumer's obligation to carry out the repair works and to notify WSD of the completion of the repair works;
- (ii) the possible consequence of the non-compliance of the repair notice i.e. disconnection of water supply to the concerned premises; and
- (iii) the need to notify WSD of the completion of the repair works if the responsible consumer has already completed the repair works prior to receipt of the repair notice.

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

- (c) Sample repair notices for potable and flushing water supply systems are at **Appendix 2.19 and Appendix 2.20** respectively.
- (d) If the complainant cannot be contacted for checking the latest seepage condition within 5 working days from the receipt of the JO's referral, Region(CS)(I) staff should issue a letter to the complainant requiring him/her to contact WSD for updating the seepage condition. A sample letter to the complainant is at **Appendix 2.21**. Region(CS)(I) staff should keep the case under review until the complainant has contacted them.
- (e) If the JO's report or JO's memo has no clear conclusion whether the seepage is caused by water supply pipe leakage (such as positive meter flow check test or RPT), E/Region(CS)(I) should issue a memo to the JO seeking clarification. A sample memo to the JO is at **Appendix 2.22**. If such clarification is not received after 5 working days, E/Region(CS)(I) should escalate the case to CE/Region for following up with the JO.

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

- (f) If there is insufficient evidence of waste of water for taking enforcement action (see subsection 2.2.8.3(a) above on the conclusive evidence required), E/Region(CS)(Inspection) should issue a memo to the JO to return the case to them. A sample memo to the JO is at **Appendix 2.23**. E/Region(CS)(I) should also issue a letter to the complainant informing him/her that there is insufficient evidence of waste of water for taking enforcement action under WWO. A sample letter is at

Appendix 2.24 (pages 1 & 2). Moreover, for cases where it is likely that the seepage is caused by water supply pipe leakage but there is insufficient evidence of waste of water for taking enforcement action²², E/Region(CS)(I) should issue an advisory letter, a sample of which is at **Appendix 2.24** (pages 3 & 4), to the responsible consumer advising him/her to engage a licensed plumber or qualified professional to check the inside service of his/her premises and advising him / her to repair any defective water supply pipes or installations identified.

[Paragraph update in January 2025 version]

- (g) If a report providing the conclusive evidence of waste of water as required in subsection 2.2.8.3(a) above is not included in JO's referral, WI/Region(CS)(I) should report to E/Region(CS)(I) who should immediately request the JO to provide the report within 5 working days. A sample memo to the JO is at **Appendix 2.25**. If the report is not received after 5 working days, E/Region(CS)(I) should escalate the case to CE/Region for following up with the JO.
- (h) A flow chart showing the procedure and timeframe of handling water seepage complaints referred from the JO is at **Annex A of Appendix 2.26**.

2.2.7.4 Water Seepage Complaints Received Directly by WSD

- (a) If WSD receives a water seepage complaint directly from the complainant who does not allege that the cause of the seepage is due to water supply pipe leakage, Region(CS)(I) staff should check the record of WSD whether a referral has been received from the JO for the case. If affirmative, Region(CS)(I) staff should inform the complainant that the case is being handled by WSD. If not, E/Region(CS)(I) should refer the case to the JO for investigation. In addition, E/Region(CS)(I) should reply to the complainant to explain that the JO is the first contact point responsible for handling water seepage complaint and his/her case has been referred to the JO for investigation. A sample reply to the complainant, with a copy to the JO, is at **Appendix 2.27**.
- (b) However, if the complainant alleges that the seepage is due to water supply pipe leakage, Region (CS)(I) staff should contact the complainant for more details such as whether the complainant has actually seen any pipe leak and the following steps should be taken:-

²² Advisory letters should be issued in the following scenarios:-

- (a) Cases from the JO with positive Static Pressure Test (SPT) result and without any indication of positive 30-minute water meter flow check test / RPT result; or
- (b) Cases from the JO with positive RPT results based on measurements of moisture content only (i.e. no continuous dripping).

[Footnote added in January 2025 version]

- (i) If the complainant advises that there is no visible pipe leak, Region(CS)(I) staff should explain to the complainant that the JO is the first contact point responsible for handling water seepage complaints and his/her case will be referred to the JO for investigation. E/Region(CS)(I) should refer the case to the JO as mentioned in subsection 2.2.8.4(a) above.
- (ii) If the complainant advises that there is a visible pipe leak, Region(CS)(I) staff should carry out inspection and testing (including visual inspection and the 30-minute water meter flow check). If there is no conclusive evidence of waste of water after the investigation, E/Region(CS)(I) should refer the case to the JO. A sample reply to the complainant, with a copy to the JO, is at **Appendix 2.28**. If the inspection and testing provides conclusive evidence of waste of water, a repair notice shall be issued in accordance with subsection 2.2.8.3(c) above.

2.2.7.5 Procedure for Handling Mis-assigned 1823 Complaints Related to Water Seepage/Leakage Case

- (a) Very often, the public have mistaken (i) water seepage/dripping to be originated from defective water supply pipes of (ii) defective drain pipes as defective water supply pipes which would mislead 1823 to mis-assign these types of complaints to WSD. In a full investigation into a complaint case, the Ombudsman considers that WSD has room for improvement in handling a water seepage/leaking case which was subsequently confirmed not under WSD's purview. In order to render prompt and quality service to the public even through the complaints/enquiries/issues are not related to water supply, WSD needs to adopt more proactive measures and adequate actions to endeavor timely handling of complaints by the appropriate government department.
- (b) For cases involving alleged defective water pipes which are subsequently confirmed on site by CS Inspection Team as defective exposed drain pipe or water dripping from air-conditioner/cooling tower, the subject officer shall inform 1823 the mis-assignment of case within 7 calendar days, and request 1823 to re-assign the case to the appropriate department (i.e. Buildings Department for defective exposed drain pipe in building, and Food and Environmental Hygiene Department for water dripping from air-conditioner/cooling tower) with record photos provided as justification.

Time Limit for Repair Works

- 2.2.7.6 The responsible WI/Region(CS)I or above should specify in the Repair Notice a due date

for the consumer/agent to carry out the rectification works, taking into account various factors including seriousness and consequence of the irregularity, difficulty of the rectification works and the number of consumers/occupiers affected, etc. An array of factors for determination of the time limit for carrying out the rectification works is given in **Appendix 2.52**. It should be noted that the time limits set out in **Appendix 2.52** serve as a general guideline only and special circumstances may justify a shorter/longer time limit for carrying out the rectification works. The responsible WI/Region(CS)I or Engineer of CS Inspection Team (E/Region(CS)I) should seek steer from their SE/Region(CS) if a time limit shorter/longer than those in **Appendix 2.52** is proposed for carrying out the rectification works. Such justification for a time limit shorter/longer than those in **Appendix 2.52** should be recorded in CCBS.

- 2.2.7.7 Upon the expiry of the time limit for the repair works or when the repair works are reported to be completed by the responsible consumer, whichever is earlier, the CSI concerned should carry out an inspection to ascertain completion of the repair works. Moreover, the CSI should contact the complainant requesting an inspection of his/her premises for checking whether the water dripping still persists. Compliance of the repair notice should consider factors such as the basis of issuing repair notice (based on conclusive evidence by visible leakage, 30-minute water meter flow check test or RPT), any signs of repair and the dripping conditions. For cases when the Repair Notice was based on RPT results from the JO, the compliance matrix shown in **Annex A of Appendix 2.26** should be followed. Otherwise, the following scenarios may arise:-

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

(a) Case (A) – Cessation of water dripping

If the water dripping has ceased, the CSI is required to inspect the inside service of the premises under complaint to ascertain if the repair notice has been complied with. If the repair works have been completed, the case should be closed and the complainant should be advised accordingly. A sample of the reply letter is at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 1 & 2). If the responsible consumer cannot be contacted or an inspection of the premises under complaint cannot be arranged, the CSI should conduct a 30-minute water meter flow test for the premises²³. If the result is negative, the case should be closed and the complainant should be advised accordingly using the sample letter at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 1 & 2). If the result is positive and it is confirmed that there is no water consumption in the premises during the water meter

²³ For cases when the Repair Notice was based on RPT results from the JO, the compliance matrix shown in **Annex A of Appendix 2.26** should be followed. For a flushing water supply case where the 30-minute water meter flow check cannot be carried out, the E/Region(CS)(Inspection) should revisit the case after 7 days and if the cessation of water dripping remains unchanged, the case should be closed with the complainant advised accordingly using the sample letter at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 3 & 4).

[Updated in January 2025 version]

flow test period, it should indicate that the water supply pipes of the premises are still leaking. The E/Region(CS)(I) should consider whether the repair notice has not been complied with or it is a new water supply pipe leakage of the premises under complaint. If the former, he should issue a disconnection notice to the responsible consumer, with a copy to the occupier of the premises, and proceed with the procedure of disconnecting the water supply to the premises pursuant to DI No. 919. A sample disconnection notice is at **Appendix 2.30**. If the latter, the E/Region(CS)(I) should close the current case and issue a new repair notice to the responsible consumer. In both cases, the complainant should be advised accordingly. A sample letter to the complainant is at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 1 & 2).

(b) Case (B) – Water dripping still persists

- (i) If the water dripping still persists and the inspection also indicates that the repair works have not been completed, E/Region(CS)(I) should issue a disconnection notice to the responsible consumer, with a copy to the occupier of the premises under complaint and the JO, and proceed with the procedure of disconnecting the water supply to the premises pursuant to DI No. 919. A sample disconnection notice is at **Appendix 2.30**. E/Region(CS)(I) should advise the complainant accordingly using the sample letter at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 1 & 2).
- (ii) If the responsible consumer has carried out repair works and yet water dripping at the complainant's premises still persists, the CSI should conduct a 30-minute water meter flow test for the premises. If the result is positive, E/Region(CS)(I) should consider to issue a disconnection notice to the responsible consumer, with a copy to the occupier of the premises under complaint and the JO, and proceed with the procedure of disconnecting the water supply to the premises pursuant to DI No. 919. A sample disconnection notice is at **Appendix 2.30**. The complainant should be advised accordingly using the sample letter at **Appendix 2.29** (pages 1 & 2). If the result is negative, CS (Inspection) staff should refer the case to the JO for further investigation of the source of the water seepage which may be caused by multiple sources. A sample letter informing the complainant is at **Appendix 2.31**, and a sample memo referring the case to JO for further investigation is at **Appendix 2.32**.

2.2.7.8 In some cases, it may be considered necessary to inspect the premises under complaint to ascertain whether the repair works have been completed but the responsible consumer cannot be contacted or refuses entry of the CSI to his premises for the inspection. E/Region(CS)(I) should issue a notice to the responsible consumer requiring him to make arrangement within a specified time to enable WSD's staff to enter his premises for the

inspection, with a copy to the occupier of the premises. A sample notice is at **Appendix 2.33**. If such arrangement is not made within the period specified, E/Region(CS)(I) should issue a disconnection notice to the responsible consumer, with a copy to the occupier of the premises, and proceed with the procedure of disconnecting the water supply to the premises pursuant to DI No. 919 A sample disconnection notice is at **Appendix 2.34**.

Extension of Time (EOT) to Complete the Repair Works

- 2.2.7.9 Difficulties may be encountered by the responsible consumer in carrying out the repair works to the leaking water supply pipe. When the responsible consumer requires a longer time for the repair works, he needs to apply to the Water Authority for EOT in writing stating the grounds for EOT. The approving officer should carefully consider the grounds provided with due consideration of the nuisance being caused to the complainant.
- 2.2.7.10 EOT should only be granted under special circumstances provided that full justification is given by the responsible consumer, together with solid evidence showing his willingness and readiness to complete the repair works within a reasonable time having due regard to the nuisance being caused to the complainant. EOT should be granted by an officer of at least one grade/rank higher than the one who signed the Repair Notice in accordance with the respective approving authorities for EOT as listed in **Appendix 2.12**.
- 2.2.7.11 It should be noted that the samples of correspondence provided in the Appendices under Section 2.2.8 are for reference only. They should be modified to suit the specific situations of individual cases.
- 2.2.7.12 For cases which cannot be resolved or there are different views between WSD and JO at working level, the E/Region(CS)(I) should promptly escalate the case to his senior for following up with the JO. However, E/Region(CS)(I) should consider arranging necessary joint inspection with JO to resolve differences prior to escalating the case to his senior.
- 2.2.7.13 For cases which cannot be processed due to denial of entry to the premises under complaint, the E/Region(CS)(I) should take decisive action requesting arrangement be made within a specified time to enable WSD's staff to enter the premises similar to the action in subsection 2.2.8.7 above.

Monitoring Mechanism

- 2.2.7.14 WI/Region(CS)(I) should keep a register of all seepage cases and keep track of their progress to ensure timely actions are taken. These cases should be recorded in **Appendix 1.1**. SEs/Region(CS) should monitor the progress of the seepage cases by using the sort” function of the register on a biweekly basis and bring up any difficult and

problematic cases to CE/Region for steering in a timely manner.

[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

- 2.2.7.15 CE/Region should review the overall progress in the handling of seepage cases with SE/Region(CS) on a monthly basis and determine appropriate actions to be taken to prevent long outstanding and unresolved cases. Cases with great difficulties should be brought up to AD/Urban or AD/NT for steering.

2.2.8 Positive 30-minute Water Meter Flow Check Test

- 2.2.8.1 Subsection 2.2.8.3(a)(ii) describes the positive 30-minute water meter flow check test. When the occupier of the suspected seepage causing flat has stopped consuming water for 30 minutes, the corresponding water meter has recorded “a reading”, which indicates the existence of water supply pipe leakage.

- 2.2.8.2 A record of reading means that there is clear and noticeable movement of the last meter dial even though the movement is minute. The scale division after the last digit is to grade the reading of last digit further into equal volumes by horizontal lines (see **Appendix 2.35**). Any movement of the scale division with respect to the horizontal line should be readily noticeable and regarded as "a reading".

[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

2.2.9 Supplementary Guidelines on Handling Water Seepage Complaints

Supplementary guidelines on handling seepage complaint

- 2.2.9.1 To further enhance the efficiency and effectiveness in handling seepage complaint, the following supplementary guidelines on handling seepage complaints are to be observed:

(a) Contacting the RC of the premises under complaint for investigation

Subsection 2.2.8.7 states that if the responsible consumer cannot be contacted or refuses entry of the CSI for 'repair notice compliance inspection', a Notice should be issued to the responsible consumer requiring him to make arrangement within a specified time to enable WSD's staff to enter his premises for carrying out the inspection. It is specified in the Notice that should the responsible consumer fail to make such arrangements within the prescribed timeframe, the Water Authority may disconnect the water supply to his premises pursuant to Section 10(h) of the WWO. The same procedures of issuing a Notice specifying the possible disconnection of water supply should apply to situation where the responsible consumer fails to respond to our request for entry or refuse to provide entry during investigation stage.

(b) Issuing of repair notice

There may be cases that RC of the premises under complaint admits that his inside service is in defective condition and he undertakes to arrange a plumber to carry out the repair works. To speed up the processing of the seepage complaint, if there is evidence suggesting that the premises under complaint is the source of seepage (e.g. the seepage has persisted and the water meter of the premises concerned is found registering even when there is no one inside) and the RC concerned has admitted his liability for the seepage, the case officer should issue a repair notice to the RC concerned as soon as possible irrespective of whether he has undertaken to carry out repair works to his defective inside services.

(c) Suspension of water supply in case of emergency

If there is conclusive evidence of seepage caused by water supply pipe leakage and that the seepage has caused serious damage to properties or risk to lives, the case officer should immediately suspend the supply of the premises concerned by virtue of Section 9(e) of WWO and should not wait for the RC concerned to complete the repair works.

2.2.10 Early Investigation for Seepage

2.2.10.1 The Task Force on Review of Operations of the Joint Office of Water Seepage has agreed to formalise the trial of Early Investigation for Seepage referral mechanism carried out during December 2019 to November 2020 as a standing arrangement with effect from 15 March 2021. The flowchart in **Annex B of Appendix 2.24** illustrated the workflow of the whole mechanism.

[Paragraph updated in November 2021, January 2024 and January 2025 versions]

2.2.10.2 Under the standing referral mechanism, JO or JO's consultants will refer seepage complaint cases to WSD for direct follow-up if the screening criteria below are met:

- (i) JO or JO's consultants conducted inspection and confirmed that the dripping rate is greater than or equal to 20 drops per minute²⁴; and
- (ii) dripping rate remains unchanged throughout the day.

2.2.10.3 In regard to the above standing arrangement, Region CS (Inspection) Teams should handle

²⁴ JO or JO's consultants will refer cases to WSD at any stage of their investigation as long as the screening criteria are met.

the seepage cases referred from JO or his consultants according to the salient points below in handling the cases:

- (i) contact the complainant and the upper flat for arrangement of inspection and meter flow test within three working days from the receipt of the case referred from JO as far as practicable;
- (ii) inspect the lower flat and record the dripping rate and location;
- (iii) record if there is any visible leakage from the exposed water supply pipes and carry out chloride residual test with valid test paper if the leakage point is accessible. A 30-minute water meter flow test should also be performed at the upper flat even though no dripping is observed. Such observations should be recorded on the Proforma as attached in **Appendix 2.36** and return the case to JO for Stage 2 Investigation (i.e. to consider carrying out RPT) with such observation;
[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]
- (iv) inform JO the result of water meter flow test within five working days as far as practicable;
- (v) complete the proforma in the **Appendix 2.36** and upload to the CCBS for record; and
- (vi) submit monthly summary at **Appendix 2.37** to E/TS(1).

2.2.10.4 For cases with conclusive evidence (such as visible leakage or positive 30-minute water meter flow test), enforcement action should be taken according to Section 2.2.8. Otherwise, the cases should be referred back to JO for further investigation of the seepage source. For the later, the complainant should be advised that his/her complaint will be referred back to JO for follow-up action. Do not inform the complainant any information concerning the JO's follow-up action, which is under the ambit of JO.

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

2.2.10.5 JO will refer cases to WSD in memo form, while JO's consultant will refer cases to WSD in letter form²⁵. The content of the referral memo/letter will include the complainant's contact, address of the concerned premises and the inspection details.

2.2.10.6 JO or JO's consultant will also refer cases with positive RPT result or visible leakage on water supply pipe to WSD. Region CS (Inspection) Teams should observe the guidelines stipulated in Section 2.2.8. However, 20 drops criteria should not be applicable to referral cases concerning visible leakage of water supply pipe.

2.2.10.7 If there are cases referred from 1823 direct, return the cases to 1823 for them to revert the

²⁵ All referral memo/letter should be addressed to DMC. In case Region receive referral memo/letter directly from JO or JO's consultants, please inform DMC for update of record and remind JO or JO's consultants to send the forthcoming cases to DMC.

cases back to JO for site verification.

- 2.2.10.8 Once Regions (CS) have completed the inspection, a substantive reply should be issued to the complainant regardless of the results. In case that investigation is further required by JO, Regions (CS) should reply the complainant with the letter template from **Appendix 2.27** and **Appendix 2.28** of the S&DB Handbook (CS) Volume 2. Otherwise, Regions (CS) should use the letter template in **Appendix 2.38** for the substantive reply.

2.2.11 “Special Channel” for Seepage Cases Referred by JO as Requested by Complainant
[New section incorporated in January 2024 version]

- 2.2.11.1 In some cases, the complainant would strongly request the JO to refer the case to WSD. To deal with such cases, the Task Force on Review of Operations of the Joint Office of Water Seepage agreed in the meeting on 17 January 2023 that a new “Special Channel” referral mechanism would be established on the same date. Under this referral mechanism, JO would refer the case to WSD at the strong request of the complainant, and would specify such request in the referral memo. In such situation, WSD would take initial action within 14 working days from the receipt of the request from JO as if it is received directly from the complainant as shown in Part 4(ii) of the **Appendix 1.2**.
- 2.2.11.2 To monitor the situation of the referral mechanism, Region (CS) Inspection Team should keep record of the cases referred under the “Special Channel” and provide the return as stated in **Appendix 2.38** to E/TS(1) at the end of each month for reporting at Joint Core Team Meeting.

2.2.12 Decision Hierarchy for Handling Cases of Underground Private Water Main Leakage
[New section incorporated in November 2021 version]

Issue of Repair Notice (Form WWO 48)

- 2.2.12.1 When the prima facie case of underground private water main leakage is established and the responsible party (i.e. the registered agent, incorporated owner, management office or other owners’ representative) is identified, as the first and foremost action, repair notice (Form WWO 48) should be issued to the responsible party as soon as practicable. In the repair notice, a reasonable time limit for the responsible party to complete the repair works to the leaking private main should be specified in accordance with the guidelines provided in Section 2.2.2. In order to facilitate the carrying out of the repair works, technical advice and a list of Licensed Plumbers (LPs) may be provided to the responsible party for reference.

Pressure Reduction or Flow Restriction

- 2.2.12.2 To prevent waste of water, before completion of the repair works under Section 9 of WWO, Region (CS) staff should consider restricting water supply by means of pressure reduction or flow restriction if practicable. To this end, pressure reduction should be considered first by adjusting the pressure reducing valve if it is present in the concerned pressure management area without affecting the normal water supply to other premises. Alternatively, the water flow can be restricted by throttling the control valve in the associated government water main with the assistance from Region (Distribution) if necessary.

If the responsible party fails to complete the repair works within the time limit specified in the repair notice, unless there are strong grounds submitted by the responsible party to WSD to apply for extension of time, the extent of pressure reduction or flow restriction should be stepped up²⁶ to further minimize the water loss. The responsible party should be notified of the situation and urged to complete the repair works as soon as practicable. However, if further restriction of the water supply becomes impracticable having regard to fulfilling the basic need of water demand by the premises concerned, consideration should be given to stepping-in the premises to carry out the repair works by WSD as outlined in Section 2.2.12.3.

Stepping-in to Carry out Repair Works

- 2.2.12.3 Notwithstanding that the responsible party has the responsibility under Section 7 of WWO to maintain the private water main, subject to the satisfaction of all of the following conditions, the CE/Region should critically review if it is justifiable for WSD to step-in to carry out the repair works to the leaking private water mains under Section 17 of WWO:
- (i) further restriction of water supply becomes impracticable;
 - (ii) the responsible party has great difficulty in coordinating the repair works (e.g. cases of 3-nil building, the registered consumer (RC) with part of his inside service in area owned by another party and agreement cannot be obtained²⁷);
 - (iii) the number of consumers affected due to suspension of water supply is large;
 - (iv) the responsible party agrees on the step-in arrangement for the Water Authority to carry out the repair works and undertakes to bear the repair cost by signing the WWO 1155; and
 - (v) resources of the Region concerned are available.

²⁶ Normally the pressure will not be reduced to a level lower than the WSD's pledge. That said, for special circumstances and subject to CE/Region's agreement, the pressure could be reduced to a level lower than the WSD's pledged level.

²⁷ For this case, opportunity should be taken to advise the RC to relocate the concerned part of the inside service as far as practicable.

Despite the conditions stated above, step-in repair works should still be considered at all time under the special circumstances below:

- (i) the concerned development is an essential installation such that human life or social order would be at stake when water supply is not available (e.g. hospitals and penal institutions), or
- (ii) any emergency situation.

2.2.12.4 When WSD decides to step in to carry out the repair works to the leaking private water main, Region (CS) staff should request Region (Distribution) staff to arrange the WSD's term contractor to carry out the repair works. Region (CS) staff should be responsible for the coordination of the repair works and the subsequent recovery of the cost of the repair works from the responsible party. Prior to the commencement of the repair works, the scope and details of the repair works should be agreed with the responsible party and explicitly recorded by stating in the signed WWO 1155. In this connection, disclaimer shall be made as to the repair works not covering surface reinstatement of finishing, and WSD has no liability on any accidental damage to the property of the concerned development for the purpose of carrying out the repair works.

2.2.12.5 If the responsible party refuses to sign the WWO 1155 as above, CE/Region should consider stepping-in to carry out the repair works under Section 17(4) of WWO. In case WSD' entry into the private lot for carrying out the repair works is refused by the responsible party, Region (CS) staff should, after obtaining consent from CE/Region, consider obtaining a warrant under Section 12 of WWO for Region (Distribution) staff to enter the premises concerned for carrying out the repair works.

2.2.12.6 In case there is no RA for communal service and step-in to fix the defect is necessary, Regions (CS) Inspection Team should make every endeavour to obtain a signed WWO 1155 from occupant(s) or their representative(s) (such as Management office or Incorporated owners) of the premises to request the WA to carry out repair works. According to WWO/WR, WA can only recover the cost of repair works from the RA or the person who signed WWO 1155. If there is no RA and a signed WWO 1155 is not available, Region (CS) staff should inform Region (Distribution) that the works order should be classified as "non-recoverable" job in MWMS since the subsequent recovery of the cost of repair works is not feasible.

[New paragraph incorporated in January 2025 version]

Suspension²⁸ of Water Supply

²⁸ Suspension of water supply will be effected without physical removal of the associated control valve.

- 2.2.12.7 If it is not considered justifiable to stepping-in to carry out the repair works under Section 17(4) of WWO as mentioned in Section 2.2.12.3, CE/Region should consider suspending the water supply to the premises concerned under Section 9 of WWO. In arriving at the decision on suspension of water supply, the resources implication arising from provision of temporary fresh water supply to the premises concerned should also be fully deliberated. CE/Region and Region (CS) staff should follow the notification procedures as set out in para. 8 of DI No. 919 for suspension of water supply.

2.2.13 Verification on CSI's Inspection

- 2.2.13.1 To detect and deter malpractices in water seepage and leakage cases, each Region should have at least 2 site inspection per month for leakage/seepage cases conducted by CSI together with his supervisor, i.e. AWI, who should check and verify the CSI's inspection. Priority should be given to those site inspections that are not the first site inspection of the leakage/seepage case.

2.3 Meters

2.3.1 Resiting of Water Meter Position

- 2.3.1.1 This section promulgates procedures of the WSD in consulting the consumer to resite the water meter position and the subsequent disconnection of water supply if the relevant consumer refuses to resite the meter position. The following procedures are for handling cases of resiting of water meter(s). Region (CS) staff should try all possible means including but not limited to applying for a warrant to gain access to the water meter prior to the resiting of meter position.
- 2.3.1.2 From time to time, Region (CS) staff are often required to access to the water meters for carrying out inspection, routine maintenance or meter replacement works to ensure proper functioning of the meters. However, water meters may be inaccessible under different situations such as:-
- (a) the meter was not sitting in an accessible location;
 - (b) physical obstruction to the meter's location; or
 - (c) denial of entry by the occupier / vacant premises.
- 2.3.1.3 Under the above situations, the WA will normally suggest the relevant RC/RA to resite the meter position. However, the RC/RA is usually unwilling to cooperate. Having consulted LAD for legal advice, it was confirmed that disconnection of water supply to the premises concerned could be proceeded if the RC/RA refused to resite their meter position. In this regard, we should check whether disconnection of water supply to the premises concerned can be carried out technically. If it is confirmed that the disconnection can be carried out by disconnecting the inside service at an appropriate position other than the meter position or at the supply connection outside the lot boundary which solely supplies water to the premises concerned, the WA may proceed with the workflow stipulated from subsection 2.3.1.4 onwards to request the RC/RA to carry out the resiting of meter position.
- 2.3.1.4 E/Region(CS)I should issue a letter to the relevant RC/RA informing him/her of the inaccessible meters and suggesting him/her to resite the meters position, with a copy to the MO and occupier of the premises. A sample letter is at **Appendix 2.40**.
- 2.3.1.5 If there is no response from the relevant RC/RA within 1 month after the date of the letter, or the relevant RC/RA refuses the resiting of meter position, E/Region(CS)I should, according to regulation 27(2) of the Waterworks Regulations, issue a consultation letter with a proposal for the resiting of meter position to the relevant RC/RA, with a copy to the MO and occupier of the premises. The RC/RA will be invited

to provide his/her opinions on WSD's proposal for the resiting of meter position within 14 days after the date of the consultation letter. A sample consultation letter is at **Appendix 2.41**.

- 2.3.1.6 If there is no response from the relevant RC/RA within the period specified in the consultation letter, E/Region(CS)I should issue a reminder, inviting the relevant RC/RA to provide his/her opinions within 14 days after the date of the reminder. If there is still no response from the relevant RC/RA after serving two reminders at 14 days intervals, or the relevant RC/RA refuses the WSD's proposal on the resiting of meter position, E/Region(CS)I should issue a notice to the relevant RC/RA requesting him/her to submit application form WWO 542 with a proposal for resiting the meter position within 14 days after the date of the notice for the WA's consideration, with a copy to the MO and occupier of the premises. The relevant RC/RA should be reminded in the notice that until the associated works for resiting the meter position is carried out, the inside services concerned shall be regarded as not complying with the Waterworks Ordinance. A sample notice is at **Appendix 2.42**.
- 2.3.1.7 If such application is not submitted by the relevant RC/RA within the period specified in the notice, E/Region(CS)I should issue a reminder, urging the relevant RC/RA to submit application within 14 days after the date of the reminder. If there is still no response from the relevant RC/RA after serving two reminders at 14 days intervals, or the relevant RC/RA refuses the resiting of meter position, E/CS(Inspection) should issue a disconnection notice to the relevant RC/RA pursuant to section 10(c) of the Waterworks Ordinance, with a copy to the occupier of the premises, and proceed with the procedure of disconnecting the water supply to the premises concerned pursuant to DI No. 919. A sample disconnection notice is at **Appendix 2.43**.
- 2.3.1.8 A flow chart showing the procedure and timeframe of handling inaccessible water meters is at **Appendix 2.44**. For cases with great difficulties or uncertainties, advice from SE/Region(CS) should be sought.

2.3.2 Review on Meter Size in Respect of Trade Account Meters with Frequent Replacement

Frequent meter replacement

- 2.3.2.1 There are cases of repeated replacement of meters serving the same premises because of under-sizing of meters. Under the current practice, a Field Activity (FA) of meter replacement will be triggered if an "NR" (meter not registering and there should be water consumption) MR code or three consecutive times of zero consumption with different combinations of "VT", "ZT" or "ZX" MR code are registered for (i) meters of age 9

years or above or (ii) the assessed ~10% priority meters of age less than 9 years. The meter-replacement FA will be automatically sent to the CWI/Works of each Region who will then assign the job to the staff of the Works Team of the Region. Unless specified otherwise, Works Team will replace the defective meter with a new one of the same size. It is thus likely that cases of repeated replacement due to under-sizing of the meter will only be detected when the occurrence of meter replacement and/or estimation of water bill due to defective meter of the same account become so frequent that has caught the attention of the case officer(s), or worse still, when the RC lodges a complaint against WSD.

Actions to be taken on reviewing meter size

- 2.3.2.2 CS/Regional staff are reminded to be on the lookout for undersized meter cases. If Works Team finds that the meter of a premises, particularly if it is a small-size meter (i.e. 15 mm or 25 mm meter) of a trade account (e.g. supply to restaurant) or a communal meter (e.g. TMF supply), has been replaced frequently within a relatively short period of time (e.g. more than once within two years), it may refer the case to the Inspection Team for investigating as to whether the meter is undersized and meter enlargement is necessary. In addition, CAS will also refer the suspected cases to the Inspection Team for investigation. Upon receipt of the referral from the Works Team / CAS, the Inspection Team should investigate into the case by reviewing the past consumption of the account, conducting site inspection, if necessary, and take appropriate follow-up action. If meter enlargement is required, the Inspection Team should inform the Works Team of the appropriate size of meter to be installed and, if necessary, request the RC to alter the inside service for the installation of a larger meter.
- 2.3.2.3 In case that a request to the RC for meter enlargement works is required, Regions(CS) Inspection Team should use the standard letter and memo templates in the **Appendix 2.45** to the RC and **Appendix 2.46** to Housing Department as appropriate.

2.3.3 Liability of the Consumers for Defective Meters and Meters Found Tampered with

- 2.3.3.1 When meters are found defective (apart from those reported by Meter Readers) or having been tampered with, such as being fixed in the wrong way round, actions should normally be taken under the provisions of the following sections of the WWO/WWR:-
- (a) Section 7(1)(c)(ii) of the WWO – The consumer accepts responsibility for the custody and maintenance of the fire service or inside service and the custody of any meter pertaining to the fire service or inside service.

(a) Regulation 28(2) of the WWR - Where a meter is damaged and the Water Authority is of the opinion that such damage is not the result of fair wear and tear, or where a meter is interfered with, the consumer responsible for the custody of the meter shall, without prejudice to any penalty provided for the offence, be liable to pay —

- (i) the charge prescribed in Part 1 of Schedule 1 for testing the meter;
- (ii) the cost of repairing the meter;
- (iii) any damage or loss suffered thereby by the Water Authority; and
- (iv) the charge prescribed in Part 1 of Schedule 1 for reconnecting the fire service or inside service.

2.3.3.2 However, due to varying circumstances, and taking into consideration the siting condition of the meters in some public housing estates, strict application of the above provision often leads to queries and complaints. It is therefore decided that when dealing with such cases, our staff should look for evidence of wilful damage or tampering of the meter, or even motive for such. If there is no evidence readily available, the RC, or the occupier, should be given the benefit of doubt and should not be required to pay for testing and repair of the meter.

2.3.4 Meter Arrangement Check

2.3.4.1 Should there be situation when verifying a specific meter measuring the water consumption of the water use address as it was recorded in CCBS is needed, for example, in dealing with complaint about innacurrate meter read, Meter Arrangement Check (MAC) could be carried out for this purpose. Unless all the pipe downstream of the concerned meters are all exposed and be able to visuablly inspected, MAC would need to be carried out the confirm the meter arrangement.

2.3.4.2 MAC could be carried out by mean of on/off test as appropriate, by following the below procedure:

- 1) Ensure all the water use device(s) and water tap(s) are turned off inside the water use address, observe the corresponding meter to ensure there is no movement on the dial of the meter
- 2) Turn on water tap(s) inside the water use address, observe the corresponding meter to ensure the dial of the meter is moving.

2.3.4.3 If wrong meter arrangement is found, staff of Regional (CS) Offices should rectify the records and notify staff of CA Section to take follow up action accordingly.

2.4 Unauthorised Construction/Alteration of Inside Service and Fire Service

2.4.1 Termination of Unauthorized Connections Referred by the Prosecution Unit

2.4.1.1 Upon completion of an investigation by the PU and if terminating an unauthorized connection is required, the PU will notify Region(CS) staff, within three working days from the date of completion of investigation, for follow up actions. Region(CS) staff shall take the following steps:

Step	Action to be taken	Target for completion
1.	Issue a repair notice (Form WWO 48) to the offender requiring the offender to rectify the unauthorized connection which is not metered. Depending on the complication of the plumbing arrangement involved, 7 days or 14 days will be allowed for the offender to arrange a licensed plumber to carry out the rectification work.	Within 5 working days upon receipt of notification form PU.
2.	Carry out inspection to confirm if the rectification work required by Form WWO 48 has been complied with.	Within 5 working days working days after the expiry date of Form WWO 48.
3.	Issue disconnection notice (Form WWO 47) if the unauthorized connection has not been terminated. Another 7 days will be given to the offender for rectification.	Within 3 working days after the date of the inspection in normal condition. However, it may be necessary to seek advice from DEVB and DO for some special cases or when many people will be affected by suspension of water supply. More time may be required in liaison with DO and the relevant parties.

4.	Carry out inspection after expiry date of Form WWO 47 and Region(CS) staff will terminate the unauthorized connection if it has still not been rectified by the offender.	Within 2 working days after expiry date of Form WWO 47.
5.	(a) For non-compliance and no obstruction is encountered, Region(CS) staff to disconnect the unauthorized connection.	Within 2 working days after Form WWO 47 inspection.
	(b)(i) For non-compliance and obstruction is encountered, Region(CS) staff to issue a letter to the offender demanding for provision of entry within 7 days and show intention to apply for a warrant if it is not acceded to.	Within 2 working days after Form WWO 47 inspection.
	(b)(ii) Apply for a warrant from a Magistrate if the offender refused to provide entry for the disconnection work.	Within 30 working days from the first visit for the disconnection.
6.	Terminate the unauthorized connection by Region(CS) staff, with the assistance of the Police.	The next working day after the warrant and assistance of police have been obtained, and the consumer/occupier has also been informed that a warrant has been obtained.

2.4.1.2 Every effort should be made to adhere to the targets as far as practicable. In case the targets cannot be met, the reasons causing the delay shall be properly recorded in the CCBS. The information will be useful for answering any complaint possibly arising from the delay.

2.4.1.3 Reference shall also be made to DI No. 85, DI No. 919, Section 1.4.5 and Section 2.9.1, etc., where necessary.

2.4.2 Illegal Cross Connection of Internal Potable Supply System to Flushing Supply System

- 2.4.2.1 Occasionally, consumers make illegal cross connections from internal potable supply systems to the flushing supply systems for the following reasons:-
- (a) poor maintenance and frequent breakdown of the internal flushing supply system leading to the suspension of flushing water supply;
 - (b) the private flushing supply source (e.g. well water) has dried up or has been abandoned and the tenants do not apply for government flushing water supply; and
 - (c) for some village houses, the developers only apply for potable supply to serve the houses. Without the provision of flushing water supply, some tenants subsequently have to make illegal connections from the potable supply systems to serve flushing purpose.
- 2.4.2.2 Making illegal cross connections from the internal potable supply systems to the flushing supply systems can cause contamination to the potable water supply. This malpractice is in contravention with the WWO and the offenders are liable to prosecution.
- 2.4.2.3 Whenever an illegal cross connection between the potable and flushing system is found by the Region(CS) staff, the relevant RC/RA should be required to rectify the plumbing irregularities immediately. Should the RC/RA fail to do so, action should be initiated to disconnect the water supply to the premises.
- 2.4.2.4 For cases in which there are sufficient reasons to believe that the illegal cross connection has caused contamination to the potable water supply, the flushing supply source causing the contamination should be suspended immediately. The flushing supply can only be resumed after all illegal cross connections have been removed. The cases should also be referred to the PU for follow-up action.
- 2.4.2.5 For those buildings found with the existence of many illegal cross connections, the Region(CS) staff should try to find out the causes of the problem. If it is due to the breakdown of the internal flushing supply system, the building management body (private or public) should be urged to urgently reinstate the flushing system back to the normal condition. If it is because of the drying up or abandoning of the private source, the building management body should be advised to apply for a government flushing supply without delay. As the problem of this type is usually the result of neglected maintenance of the communal part of the flushing system, the building management body must be warned that they have the responsibility to ensure the early completion of the remedial works.

Taking prosecution action against a large number of consumers may not be appropriate under this circumstance.

- 2.4.2.6 The building management body should be advised to pay particular attention to the existence of any plumbing irregularities within the building and to have them rectified immediately. They should also be advised to seek advice and assistance from WSD whenever necessary.
- 2.4.2.7 Whenever new water supply applications which only include potable supply are received (especially for village houses), the Region(CS) staff should check with the applicants any reasons for not applying for government flushing supply simultaneously and request them to apply for a flushing supply. This could avoid the situation that illegal connections are later made from the potable systems to serve flushing purpose.

2.4.3 The Use of Domestic Water Purifiers/Filters by Customers

- 2.4.3.1 When Region(CS) inspection staff discover in a domestic flat installed with a faucet or countertop type water filters or in-line filter of Point-of-use type (including in-line filter used in drinking fountain) together with backflow prevention device provided at upstream, as specified in TR, it is not necessary to request the customer to remove the filter.
- 2.4.3.2 If the Region(CS) inspection staff discover that the installation of in-line filter of Point-of-use type has not been approved by WSD, please request the customer to submit a plumbing drawing for such installation to normalise the record. If the installation of a water filter poses a threat of causing pollution of the supply but not pollution to the waterworks, inspection staff should also request the customer to disconnect the filter from the plumbing system. If such installation poses a threat of causing pollution to the waterworks, inspection staff should also take evidence and refer it to PU for investigation.
- 2.4.3.3 Despite any cases above, please also remind customers the need for proper maintenance of water tanks and pipes in their buildings so as to maintain the water quality and to reduce the possibility of pollution arising from the use of water filters. Regular maintenance of domestic water filters is also equally important.

2.5 Unlawful Taking of Water

2.5.1 Suspected Unlawful Taking of Flushing Water for Keeping Live Fish

- 2.5.1.1 On request from FEHD, if there is discovery or receipt of report of any suspected unlawful taking of flushing water for keeping live fish in fresh provision shops or market stalls selling fish, FEHD should be informed immediately. A sample memo are attached in **Appendix 2.47**.
- 2.5.1.2 The case should be referred to Prosecution Unit to take parallel or further action with FEHD.

2.5.2 Prompt Action to Cease Unlawful Taking of Water

- 2.5.2.1 Whenever a suspected case of unauthorized taking of water is referred to the Prosecution unit (PU), the staff of the PU will carry out the inspection, prepare the report, and take prosecution actions when sufficient evidence is collected. If there is no sufficient evidence for taking prosecution action, the PU will refer the case to Region (CS) for remedial actions. In order to minimize water losses due to unlawful taking of water, we should disconnect the relevant unauthorized connection as soon as possible. Hence, upon receipt of notifications from the PU, Region (CS) staff should take prompt remedial action to terminate such connections without delay.

2.5.3 Unlawful Taking of Water – Warning Letter

- 2.5.3.1 A warning letter should be issued to potential offenders of unlawful taking of water to alert them of the crime as well as the consequences of being convicted.
- 2.5.3.2 If the inside service/fire service is in such a condition that unlawful taking of water would occur (e.g. defective salt water/well water flushing system), suggestions and practicable assistance (including application forms, leaflets, links to WSD's webpage, guidelines, etc.) to make good the situation should be provided in the warning letter where appropriate.
- 2.5.3.3 Such suggestions can then be followed by the warning of the possible offences committed and the consequences of being convicted to act as a deterrent to prevent the WWO offences. In case of s29 offences, appropriate subsection of the Ordinance should be quoted. The offender should also be warned that under s35(2) he/she shall be liable to a

further fine of \$1,000 per day or part of a day during which the s29 offence continues. Please see **Appendix 2.48** for a sample of the warning letter.

2.5.4 Unlawful taking of Water through Fire Service

[Title updated in January 2025 version]

- 2.5.4.1 Taking water illegally from the hoses of the fire service systems for purposes other than fire-fighting has significant contribution to the unaccounted-for water and it is necessary to institute appropriate measures to prevent such illegal draw-off.
- 2.5.4.2 A practical approach has long been adopted by this department which requires all hoses to be housed in lockable glass-fronted cabinets. E/Region(CS), CWI/Region(CS) and S/P are reminded to make sure that our staff should strictly enforce this requirement, which is stated in the TR when they carry out inspections on fire service installations in both new and existing buildings.
- 2.5.4.3 Another way to deter illegal use of water through hoses for car / floor cleansing is to ensure that sufficient cleansing taps will be provided at each floor of car parks of a building as stated in the TR. Region(CS) staff should enforce this requirement when approving application for water supply.

2.5.5 Prioritizing Enforcement Actions against Unauthorized Fresh Water Cooling Towers (UFWCTs)

- 2.5.5.1 It is the Government policy to control the design, construction and operation of FWCTs to minimize the risk of ‘Legionnaires’ disease. FWCTs are required to be designed, constructed and operated according to a set of requirements in the “Fresh Water Cooling Towers Scheme” (the Scheme). The Water Authority will only grant written permission to use water from the waterworks for operation of the FWCTs under Regulation 13 of the Waterworks Regulations for the FWCTs which have joined the Scheme. FWCTs using water from the waterworks without the WA’s written permission are regarded as UFWCTs. It is the Government’s long term target to eliminate all UFWCTs.
- 2.5.5.2 To meet the long term target, DEVB, EMSD and WSD have jointly formulated a policy on prioritizing the enforcement action under WWO against UFWCTs. Details of the policy are attached in **Appendix 2.49**.

2.5.6 Guidelines for Cases referred to Prosecution Unit

- 2.5.6.1 Under the existing practice, when a consumer gives up the consumership, WSD will arrange to remove the meter(s) of the associated inside service if no eligible person takes up the consumership within a period of time. When the consumership is null and the meter(s) are not yet removed, if any person takes water through the meter(s) and inside service, he/she may have contravened Section 29(1)(c) of the Waterworks Ordinance for unlawful taking water.
- 2.5.6.2 E/NTW(CS)A2 should prepare a monthly list of outstanding Field Activities for disconnection due to consumership not taken up. Under the list, SE/NTW(3(should then refer those cases that fulfill the following conditions to Prosecution Unit for follow up actions; (i) the period of null consumership exceeding 120 days; and (ii) the registered consumption during the period exceeding 500m³.

2.6 Abnormal Water Consumption

2.6.1 Action on Discovered or Suspected Leakage, Wastage and High Consumption of Consumers

- 2.6.1.1 Details refer to DI No. 911.
- 2.6.1.2 WSD staff are reminded to respond to complaint of higher water charge from consumer timely and follow relevant departmental guidelines and seek the advice of the supervisory staff, if considered necessary. For repeatedly inaccessible water meters and inside services in particular, Sections 1.4.2.4 and 1.4.3 of S&DB Handbook (CS) Volume 2 should be followed. If the water meters are inaccessible under different situations where resiting of their positions may be considered, Section 2.3 of S&DB Handbook (CS) Volume 2 should be followed.
[Paragraph added in January 2025 version]

2.7 Quality Water Supply Schemes for Buildings

2.7.1 Quality Water Supply Scheme for Buildings – Fresh Water (Management System) and Quality Water Supply Scheme for Buildings – Flushing Water

Details of the above two schemes and the procedures for processing the applications can be found in WSD internet homepage.

2.8 Repeated Complaints

2.8.1 Handling of Repeated Complaints or Complaints Unresolved for a Long Time by CTEC

- 2.8.1.1 CTEC staff are required to follow the procedures detailed below in handling repeated complaints or complaints unresolved for a long time.
- 2.8.1.2 The frontline CSO should become alerted when a caller claims that he/she has already raised the complaint to the CTEC several times (though to different CSOs who took his/her calls on different occasions), or his/her complaint has not yet been satisfactorily resolved for a long time. The CSO taking the call should try to obtain more information of the complaint from his/her previous calls (including when and with which telephone number(s) those calls were made). If the CSO considers it is beyond his/her capacity to resolve the complaint, he/she should bring the matter to the attention of his/her supervisor (the Team SCSO/ACO);
- 2.8.1.3 The Team SCSO/ACO should review whether an instant cure can be provided to the complaint. If the Team SCSO/ACO considers the complaint has a wide implication, he/she should raise the matter to the Group ACCM. The Group ACCM should then consolidate all information related to the case and bring it to the attention of DCCM (on account matters) or CCM (on technical, general and change of consumership matters) for formulating a strategy to handle and resolve the complaint. If the DCCM or CCM considers the matter requires co-ordination among various WSD Divisions, they should escalate the matter to E/CC.

2.9 Enforcement Action

2.9.1 Procedures of Requiring Consumer/Agent to Carry Out Repairs or Other Works to Inside Service or Fire Service

- 2.9.1.1 Pursuant to section (s.) 16 of the WWO, the WA may by notice require the consumer/agent to carry out repairs or other works specified in the notice to the inside service or fire service, if he is satisfied that an inside service or fire service:
 - (a) is in such a condition that waste or pollution of a supply has occurred or is likely to be caused thereby;
 - (b) has been altered without his permission (referred to as “unauthorized alteration” in this Section); or
 - (c) does not comply with the provisions of the WWO.
- 2.9.1.2 (a) to (c) above are collectively referred to as “irregularity” and the repairs or other works specified in the notice are collectively referred to as “rectification works” in this Section.

Cases Arising from Complaint or Internal Referral for Further Investigation

- 2.9.1.3 Upon receipt of a complaint about suspected irregularity in an inside service or fire service, or an internal To-Do referral for further investigation via the CCBS, the responsible officer of the CS Inspection Team of the relevant Region should conduct an inspection of the premises concerned as soon as practicable.
- 2.9.1.4 During the inspection, if irregularity is found in the inside service or fire service, the inspecting officer should take record of the irregularity with photographs as appropriate. Upon return to office, the inspecting officer should report his finding to the Inspector of the CS Inspection Team (WI/Region(CS)I) via the CCBS.

Entry into Premises for Inspection

- 2.9.1.5 If the premises cannot be entered (such as door unanswered) for the inspection, the inspecting officer should complete Form WWO 1142 (i.e. the Drop Card at **Appendix 1.4**) and leave it in the letter box or behind the door of the premises concerned notifying the occupier of the failed attempt of WSD's staff in entering the premises for conducting inspection. Duplicate of the Drop Card should be made as a record, and such duplicate should be uploaded to the CCBS immediately after the visit. The standard letter at **Appendix 1.5** should also be sent to the consumer/agent if his correspondence address differs from the service address. For cases where the premises still cannot be entered for conducting inspection despite the issuance of Drop Card and the standard letter, the responsible WI/Region(CS)I may consider applying for a warrant from magistrate for entry into the premises in accordance with DI No. 85 for ascertaining whether there is any contravention of the WWO / Waterworks Regulations (WWR) in respect of the inside service or fire service in the premises. Alternatively, the responsible WI/Region(CS)I may consider requiring the consumer and occupier of the premises to make reasonable arrangement for entry into the premises failing which the WA may disconnect the supply to the premises in accordance with s.10(h) of the WWO. The responsible WI/Region(CS)I should seek the steer of his SE/Region(CS) on which of the above options should be adopted for entry into the premises having regard to the circumstances.

[Paragraph updated in January 2024 version]

Issue and Administration of Repair Notice

- 2.9.1.6 If the finding of the inspection in subsection 2.9.1.4 above confirms the need of issuing a WWO 48 entitled “Notice Requiring the Consumer/Agent to Carry Out Repairs or Other Works under Section 16 of the Waterworks Ordinance (Cap. 102)” (**Appendix 2.50**) or a letter of the same effect (the notice and letter are collectively referred to as “Repair Notice” in this Section), the WI/Region(CS)I should arrange to issue the Repair

Notice as soon as practicable, preferably within 2 working days after the inspection, to the consumer/agent. In the case of inside service where the service address is not the same as the correspondence address of the consumer, a copy of the Repair Notice (without showing the correspondence address of the consumer) should also be sent to the occupier of the premises concerned. In the case of communal service²⁹, a copy of the Repair Notice (without showing the correspondence address of the agent) should also be sent to the MO and OC concerned. If no agent can be identified for the communal service, a letter at **Appendix 2.51** should be addressed to the MO and/or OC concerned, and if there is no MO or OC, the letter should be addressed to the consumers of the affected premises with copies to the occupiers (without showing the correspondence addresses of the consumers) if the service addresses are not the same as the correspondence addresses of the consumers. The authority for signing the Repair Notice is given in **Appendix 2.12**. Region GR, instead of the Document Management Centre, should print and dispatch the Notices in order to streamline the processes and save time required for generating the Notices on CCBS to dispatch to the recipient.

[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

- 2.9.1.7 The irregularity identified during the inspection and the rectification works required should be clearly stated in the Repair Notice. For leakage of communal service or fire service detected by the Water Loss Management Section, the cases should be referred to the responsible SE/Region(CS) for follow up action, including issuance of a Repair Notice or the letter at **Appendix 2.51** in accordance with subsection 2.9.1.6 above for rectification of the leakage.
- 2.9.1.8 The responsible WI/Region(CS)I or above should specify in the Repair Notice a due date for the consumer/agent to carry out the rectification works, taking into account various factors including seriousness and consequence of the irregularity, difficulty of the rectification works and the number of consumers/occupiers affected, etc. An array of factors for determination of the time limit for carrying out the rectification works is given in **Appendix 2.52**. It should be noted that the time limits set out in **Appendix 2.52** serve as a general guideline only and special circumstances may justify a shorter/longer time limit for carrying out the rectification works. The responsible WI/Region(CS)I or Engineer of CS Inspection Team (E/Region(CS)I) should seek steer from their SE/Region(CS) if a time limit shorter/longer than those in **Appendix 2.52** is proposed for carrying out the rectification works. Such justification for a time limit shorter/longer than those in **Appendix 2.52** should be recorded in CCBS.

²⁹ For the Repair Notice related to TMF supply, it should be handled in manner similar to that for communal service.

- 2.9.1.9 Subsequent to the issue of a Repair Notice, compliance inspection of the concerned premises should be made when report on completion of the rectification works is received from the consumer/agent or after the due date specified in the Repair Notice (or the extended due date if extension of time is granted), whichever is earlier. Inspection of the concerned premises should normally be carried out within 5 working days after the due date. During the compliance inspection, the inspecting officer should take photographs showing whether the rectification works specified in the Repair Notice have been satisfactorily carried out.

Rectification Works at Meter Position

- 2.9.1.10 During the replacement of meters, if there is a minor defect adjacent to the meter position such that it is necessary to replace/repair a short section of pipes and fittings of the inside service to facilitate the meter replacement, the CS Works Team should replace/repair the concerned section of pipes and fittings in conjunction with the meter replacement. However, if the defect of the pipes and fittings adjacent to the meter position is not minor, a Repair Notice should be served on the consumer requiring him to carry out the necessary rectification works before the meter replacement.

Unauthorized Alteration of Inside Service or Fire Service

- 2.9.1.11 For cases of unauthorized alteration of inside service or fire service, the following guiding principles should be followed in determining whether it is necessary to serve a Repair Notice on the consumer/agent requiring him to carry out the rectification works, and referral of the case to Prosecution Unit and Technical Support Division for further investigation and consideration of prosecution action and disciplinary action:
- (a) For unauthorized alteration that may result in contamination, wastage, misuse or loss of revenue, or adversely affect the supply system (e.g. change of supply mode to the premises from indirect to direct supply, change of meter position etc.), the I or E/Region(CS)I should serve a Repair Notice on the consumer/agent requiring him to carry out the necessary rectification works.
 - (b) For unauthorized alteration other than those mentioned in sub-paragraph (a) above, the E/Region(CS)I should issue the advisory letter at **Appendix 2.53**, instead of a Repair Notice, to the consumer/agent. No follow up action will be required subsequent to the issue of the advisory letter to the consumer/agent of the premises. Covering approval of the unauthorized alteration by WWO 542 or WWO 46 is not required.

- (c) For the unauthorized alteration of inside service or fire service under sub-paragraph (b) above, the report of inspection should be uploaded to CCBS.
- (d) Pursuant to Sections 14(1) and (2) of WWO, as soon as the unauthorized alteration is identified (except for alteration of a minor nature), the E or WI/Region(CS)I should **promptly** refer the case to the Prosecution Unit and Technical Support Division for further investigation and consideration of prosecution action for offences under WWO/WWR and/or disciplinary action on any Licensed Plumber involved in the unauthorized alteration respectively. It should be noted that prosecution action needs to be taken within 6 months beginning on the date immediately after the date on which the contravention of the WWO/WWR is discovered by, or comes to the notice of, the WA.
[Paragraph updated in January 2025 version]

Assistance from District Office (DO)

- 2.9.1.12 Difficulties may arise where rectification works are required in the communal service affecting a large number of premises and where there is no agent, MO or OC to coordinate the rectification works. In such cases, the consumers and occupiers should be advised to seek assistance from the relevant DO as necessary. The E/Region(CS)I should also write to the relevant DO requesting him to liaise with the consumers and occupiers of the affected premises as appropriate and assist them to coordinate to carry out the rectification works required in the Repair Notice.

Extension of Time (EOT) for Carrying Out the Rectification Works

- 2.9.1.13 Difficulties may sometimes be encountered by the consumer/agent in carrying out the rectification works required in the Repair Notice. If the consumer/agent requests for a longer time to carry out the rectification works, the granting of EOT may be considered provided that a written request is submitted to the WA stating the grounds for EOT to carry out the rectification works.
- 2.9.1.14 EOT will only be granted under circumstances that sound justification is provided together with evidence showing the willingness and readiness of the consumer/agent to carry out the rectification works. EOT should be given by an officer of at least one grade/rank higher than the one who signed the Repair Notice in accordance with the respective approving authorities for EOT as listed in **Appendix 2.12**.

Cancellation of Repair Notice

- 2.9.1.15 After a Repair Notice is issued, it can only be cancelled with the authority of an officer at the rank of Senior Engineer or higher.

Issue of Notice of Disconnection

- 2.9.1.16 If the requirements in the Repair Notice have not been complied with as revealed in the compliance inspection, and it is considered not advisable for WSD to step in to carry out the rectification works after review by SE/Region(CS), disconnection of supply should be implemented according to DI No. 919. For Public Rental Housing Estates and Government Buildings, the additional procedure for disconnection of supply in subsection 2.9.1.18 below should also be followed.

Licensed Food Establishment

- 2.9.1.17 If the Repair Notice is served on a licensed food establishment, a copy of the Repair Notice marked "licensed food establishment" should be sent to the Food and Environmental Hygiene Department for their information.

Public Rental Housing Estates and Government Buildings

- 2.9.1.18 For premises in Public Rental Housing Estates under the management of Housing Department (HD) or government buildings maintained by Architectural Services Department (ArchSD), the following additional procedures for the issuance of Repair Notice and Disconnection Notice should be followed :

- (a) The Repair Notice should be issued together with a letter (**Appendix 2.54**) to the consumer to advise him to liaise with HD/ArchSD if the responsibility of the rectification works does not rest with him.
- (b) At the same time, a memo (**Appendix 2.55**) should be sent to the Estate Management Division of HD / Property Services Branch of ArchSD with a copy of the Repair Notice, drawing their attention that disconnection of supply will be effected if the rectification works are not carried out on or before the due date specified in the Repair Notice. The memo should also be copied to HD/ArchSD Headquarters.
- (c) If the requirements in the Repair Notice have not been complied with, Disconnection Notice should be issued to the consumer and a memo (**Appendix 2.56**) should be sent to the Estate Management Division of HD / Property Services Branch of ArchSD with a copy of the Disconnection Notice to inform them of the

due date for disconnection of supply. The memo should also be copied to HD / ArchSD Headquarters.

- (d) Supply should be disconnected in accordance with the procedures in DI No. 919 if the requirements in the Repair Notice have not been complied with on the due date specified in the Disconnection Notice.

2.9.2 Procedures for Disconnection of Supply

Details refer to DI No. 919.

2.9.3 Action upon Discovery or Report of Contraventions of Waterworks Ordinance and Waterworks Regulations

- 2.9.3.1 Upon discovery or report of suspected contraventions of WWO and WWR, Regional staff shall take immediate action and refer the case to PU where appropriate. A list of possible contraventions of WWO/WWR with the course of action and the form for Region (CS) staff to report the cases to PU are attached at **Appendix 2.57 and Appendix 2.58** respectively. When the case is discovered during non-office hours and it should be dealt with promptly, the case should be reported to CTEC for immediate action.

3. Customer Services

3.1 Customer Telephone Enquiry Centre (CTEC)

Background

3.1.1 The CTEC was set up in 1999 as a telephone communication gateway of the WSD for her customers. It is responsible for handling communications with the public in four primary areas, namely:-

- (a) Water supply suspension;
- (b) General enquiries and complaints;
- (c) Change of Consumership; and
- (d) Account-related matters.

It integrated into one various earlier enquiry services such as the “Technical Complaints Centre”, “Enquiry Hotline” and “Water Infolink”. The CTEC provides enquiry service for customers round-the-clock throughout the year through the use of a computerized IVRS and the deployment of telephone operating officers. Operator services provided for technical services are also round-the-clock. For account-related and CoC matters, the current business hours for operator services are from 8:45 am to 6:30 pm, Monday to Saturday, except public holidays.

3.1.2 The CTEC can be reached by the public through the telephone number “2824 5000” (also commonly known as the WSD Hotline). The CTEC aims to provide one-stop shop service for all customers as far as possible. Referral of cases to the back offices (Regions, Divisions or Sections) for handling is made for more complicated cases or when direct contact or dialogue between the enquirer and staff members of specific sections is required.

CTEC Organization

3.1.3 The CTEC is headed by SE/CC who is assisted by E/CC. The CCM and DCCM are responsible to E/CC for the daily operations of the CTEC. The CCM is in charge of the “General / Technical / Mainburst”, “Control Room” and “Change of Consumership (CoC)” teams whilst the DCCM is in charge of the “Accounts” teams. The CCM and DCCM are assisted by ACCMs who lead teams of SCSOs or ACOs. Each SCSO or ACO works as the team supervisor and CSOs work as team members. The ACCM/T(1), ACCM/T(2), ACCM/T(3) and ACCM/T(4) look after the “Control Room” and the “General/Technical/Mainburst” team in shift. The ACCM/A&SS assists the CCM in

looking after the administration and system support of CTEC including the day-to-day office operations and services. The ACCM/C(1) and ACCM/C(2) look after the “Change of Consumership” teams. The ACCM/A(1), ACCM/A(2), ACCM/A(3) and ACCM/A(4) look after the “Accounts” teams.

- 3.1.4 The “General / Technical / Mainburst” teams handle enquiries on main bursts, supply faults and general matters. The “Control Room” team handles the inter-divisional and inter-departmental liaison and coordinates actions when supply suspensions, technical faults and emergency situations crop up. The team also acts as the command centre of the CTEC outside normal office hours. The “CoC” teams handle enquiries on the taking up and termination of consumership, and process such applications for domestic accounts the consumership of which is registered by an individual in his/her personal capacity. The “Accounts” teams handle account-related enquiries. A schematic organizational chart for the various teams of the CTEC is shown in **Appendix 3.1**. The manning level of each group of staff is shown in WSD Sketch No. SK60043/1 which is to be updated regularly by SE/CC to reveal the latest staff situation. The duties and responsibilities of the CCM, DCCM and ACCMs are shown in **Appendix 3.2**.

Facilitating Systems in Use in CTEC

- 3.1.5 The CTEC makes use of the following communication systems, computer systems and telephony systems for its daily running, the details of which are shown in respective sections of the CTEC Handbook.
- (a) Communication Systems - The Systems include 2 internal direct telephone lines (telephone numbers 2519 3360 and 2511 7577), the radio system and other systems to maintain effective communication with the Regional staff, other Government departments, the Security Bureau, utilities undertakers and the Police. The systems are maintained by the relevant telephone companies and computer companies with the ITPMRU providing assistance in the administration and supervision support.
 - (b) The CCBS – The CCBS includes 3 core sub-systems, namely the Oracle Utilities Customers Care and Billing, the Knowledge Base and the WSMS. The CCBS is maintained and supported by the CCBS contractor under the administration and supervision of the ITPMRU.
 - (c) Telephony Systems - The Systems include the Call Management System, Nice Logger, Wallboard System, Q-Manager, APEX IVRS and Avaya PABX System for handling calls from the public. The maintenance of the telephony systems is done by the maintenance contractor. The ITPMRU is responsible for arranging and administering the maintenance contract, strategic planning, review and upgrading of

the systems whilst the CCM is responsible for overseeing the day-to-day technical and user operation as well as providing day-to-day user support.

Water Supply Suspension

- 3.1.6 On receipt of technical enquiries and fault complaints, the CTEC should address the enquiries and complaints in the first instance using the specific information kept in the CCBS, as well as the general information provided in the guidelines and Knowledge Base of the WSD. For water suspension enquiries and complaints, the CTEC should check from the records in the CCBS whether the cause of the water suspension reported by the caller is due to his meter being removed (disconnection cases), or supply suspensions caused by planned or emergency works in the area. In case that the cause of the incident cannot be identified, a work request in the form of an ITD should be sent through the CCBS to the RCC concerned for immediate follow-up action by the concerned parties including the checking of WSD's supply system, inside service and communal service. For complaint cases, emails will also be sent to the Regional Engineers concerned, with copies to the PLMs of the concerned Region for necessary action.
- 3.1.7 On receipt of calls reporting main burst incidents to the CTEC, the "General / Technical / Mainburst" team operators should send ITDs to the RCCs concerned for their immediate follow-up action. In case the reported incident leads to a temporary suspension of water supply by the Regions, the "Control Room" team operators shall input details into the WSMS, based on the latest information input into the WSMS by the regional staff or reported to them by the Regional site staff. They should maintain close telephone contact with the regional staff in order that CTEC is kept posted promptly of details and the latest situations of the main burst incident, including progress of the repair works, anticipated supply resumption time and availability of temporary supply. They should ensure that proper updating of the incident report in the WSMS is made for all CTEC staff in responding to enquiries from the customers affected. For emergency water suspension affecting large areas and as determined by the respective Region, detailed but concise information of the case should also be recorded in the IVRS for announcement to the customers. In addition, CTEC staff shall upload the information input by Regional staff via the Electronic Services Delivery to be announced to the public in the WSD Internet. For incidents occurring outside office hours, if the Regional Duty Officer is on site, the information will be provided to CTEC staff by the Regional Duty Officer through telephone for CTEC staff to prepare the announcement. All the IVRS and Internet announcement should be vetted by the CCM (during office hours) or the duty ACCM (outside office hours) before the actual announcement in consultation with E/CC or SE/CC as necessary for complicated cases.

- 3.1.8 Outside office hours, the “Control Room” team is charged with the responsibility of mobilizing the Regional standby gangs, as well as mobilizing the WSD water wagons for providing temporary water supply to affected customers. They should contact the standby teams for water wagons or Regional staff and drivers according to the duty rosters. Whenever necessary, cross-roster calling of drivers should also be made. The CTEC staff should work hand-in-hand with the Regional Duty Officers in taking the foregoing actions.

General Enquiries

- 3.1.9 For general enquiries, such as general information on the WSD CECs, fishing licenses, plumber’s licenses, the various working procedures of the WSD, the way to complete different official forms of the department etc., the “General / Technical / Mainburst” team operators shall make use of information available in the Knowledge Base of CCBS as well as knowledge in the guidelines and practices of the WSD to answer the enquirers. When the enquiries concerned involve such depth/details of information or the specific scope of the duties and responsibilities of other regions/divisions/sections, or when referral of the enquiry to staff of the respective back offices cannot be avoided (e.g. insistence of enquirer), CTEC staff should refer the cases to the responsible staff of the concerned region / division / section for their necessary action.

Change of Consumership (of domestic accounts held by individuals)

- 3.1.10 When receiving “change of consumership” enquiries and applications, the “CoC” team operators should make use of the CCBS and act in accordance with the guidelines and practices of the WSD, namely the Standard Procedure Instructions and Procedure Handbook of Customer Accounts Section. The termination and taking-up of personal domestic accounts should be processed directly through the phone. Complicated cases that cannot be resolved straight away, such as those involving the taking-up of existing accounts with outstanding fees exceeding \$1,000, and cases that should not be processed through telephone including change of consumership of non-domestic accounts, should be referred to the Customer Accounts Section for further processing.

Account related matters

- 3.1.11 For account-related enquiries and complaints, such as requests for information on account balance / outstanding, bill calculation and interpretation, high consumption, supply disconnection, waiving of surcharges, provision of duplicate or scenario bills, change of mailing address for the register consumer, etc., the “Accounts” team operators should make use of the accounts information available in the CCBS as well as knowledge in the guidelines and practices of the WSD for the processing. For account cases that require investigations, consideration and follow-up actions by the back offices, CTEC staff should

refer the cases to the responsible officers of the CAS through To-Do's raised in the CCBS.

Procedures for Dealing with Emergency Situations and Suspension of Water Supply

- 3.1.12 The duties and responsibilities of the CTEC in handling main burst incidents and provision of emergency temporary fresh water supply to customers are described in the “Guidance Notes on Handling Main Burst and Emergency Maintenance of Water Mains” and S&DBI No.5/2018 (General).
- 3.1.13 Emergency contact telephone lists for communications within the WSD (including Regions, ITPMRU for CCBS related issues, ITDMU for network issues and the New Works Branch site project offices) as well as with other government departments, the Development Bureau, the CCBS Maintenance Contractor and telephone system provider should be updated monthly and as necessary by the CCM and then distributed to CTEC staff for efficient communication. For the contact telephone list of New Works project officers, the CCM should download the information monthly from the divisional homepages of the Construction Division, Consultant Management Division and Project Management Division, which should be updated regularly and as necessary by the relevant divisions.
- 3.1.14 For construction projects under the Construction Division of New Works Branch, the complaint hotlines of the concerned site offices are forwarded to the CTEC outside office hours. Complaints relating to these projects received via the site offices' telephone lines or CTEC direct hotline shall be referred to the concerned in-house project officers for follow-up action in accordance with the emergency contact lists with logs of the events sent to the concerned divisions/regions via email. In case immediate action is warranted, apart from informing the responsible project officer by phone and by email, CTEC staff should also contact the concerned RCC during office hour and WSD standby gangs of the concerned Regions outside office hour for immediate attendance.
- 3.1.15 From time to time, the ICC of the Efficiency Office receives main bursts and emergency cases reported by the public. ICC usually provides CTEC's hotline No. 2824 5000 for the callers to contact WSD. However, if the callers insist, the ICC will refer the reported cases to WSD by sending the case reports to the CTEC through telephone and also emailing to the PRU of WSD, quoting the reference numbers of their calls to CTEC. For these cases, the CTEC staff should deal with ICC's referral as described in Section 3.1.6, while the PRU should forward ICC's emails to the responsible officers of the concerned Regions as necessary.

Request for Mains Record Plans (MRP) from Utilities Undertakings (UUs)

- 3.1.16 WSD has to provide MRP to UUs including CLP, HKE, Town Gas, PCCW, etc to facilitate their emergency road excavation as per S&DBI No. 10/2017 (General). UUs will make such requests for WSD's MRP through the CTEC Control Room's fax no. 2519 3864. The procedure for handling the request are described in the Appendix A of S&DBI No. 10/2017 (General). The service shall be provided to the UUs round the clock. During normal office hours, when CTEC receives such requests from the UUs, CTEC staff should fax the request to Drawing Office (fax no : 2586 1683) for Drawing Office to handle the request. CTEC shall also inform the concerned Region via CCBS and also by fax and telephone stating where applicable, clearly the UU's request for WSD staff to inspect the site, in a way similar to the usual referral for attendance of main bursts incidents.
- 3.1.17 Outside office hours, CTEC staff should handle the request directly and search and generate the concerned MRP by means of the DMS. CTEC staff should then provide the MRP to the UUs by fax. CTEC staff should also inform the standby gang of the concerned Region via CCBS and also by fax and telephone, stating where applicable, clearly the UU's request for WSD staff to inspect the site in a way similar to the usual referral for attendance of main bursts incidents.

Performance Targets, Monitoring and Review

- 3.1.18 Current targets concerning the work of the CTEC in the WSD Performance Pledge include the following parameters, the performance targets of which should be subject to review and revisions regularly:-
- (a) Successful rate of measurable incoming calls connected to CTEC;
 - (b) Successful rate of calls connected to operators; and
 - (c) Waiting time for operator service.
- 3.1.19 The CTEC's actual performance in regard to the above targets and other more involved ones should be continuously measured and collected through electronic means. Weekly, monthly, quarterly and yearly monitoring reports should be produced as regular management tools for performance control and enhancement purposes. SE/CC is responsible for coordinating the preparation of the reports and submission to the management for reference. In addition, customer satisfaction surveys by independent agencies should be conducted from time to time to add new dimensions to the performance gauging processes of the CTEC. AD/NT shall initiate the customer satisfaction surveys at suitable intervals.

- 3.1.20 A detailed account of the jobs, organization structure, manning level, working procedure, functions and operations, monitoring and control of the CTEC are provided in the “CTEC Handbook” for reference of all staff members concerned. SE/CC is responsible for overseeing the accuracy of the CTEC Handbook, which should be reviewed and updated regularly in the light of changes in the foregoing aspects of CTEC.

4. Miscellaneous

4.1 User Guidelines for CCBS Data Confidentiality

Scope

- 4.1.1 This Section aims to heighten the awareness of the users of the CCBS and provide them with guidelines in respect of data confidentiality. This Section is built on the “Baseline Information Technology Security Policy for WSD (ITSP) (Version 6.0)” publicized by the Information Technology Management Unit.

Background

- 4.1.2 CCBS is opened to the system users a bank of customer information. Such access to customer information obliges users to diligently exercise due care to secure data confidentiality.
- 4.1.3 Following Section 4.1 of the ITSP, which defines confidentiality as “the condition that only authorised persons are allowed to know or gain access to the information stored or processed by Information Systems in any aspects”, data confidentiality demands protecting information from unauthorized disclosure.

Provisions of ITSP, Civil Service Regulations (CSRs), and Contracts for Data Confidentiality

- 4.1.4 WSD staff shall comply with various provisions of the ITSP, the CSRs and relevant contracts on data confidentiality. The more obvious ones are cited in subsections 4.1.5 to 4.1.8 below for easy reference of users.
- 4.1.5 All staff (i.e. persons employed by the Government irrespective of the employment period and terms) shall follow ITSP (Version 6.0) and IT Security Guidelines. Policy statements are developed for all levels of staff within WSD, including management staff, IT administrators, and general IT end users. It is the responsibility for all staff to read through the entire document to understand and follow IT security policies accordingly. The documents can be downloaded from our WSD Intranet Webpage via the following link: http://intranet5.wsd.gov/division/itmu/en/guidelines/wsd_it_security_policy/index.html
- 4.1.6 For civil servants, Reg. 524 of CSR stipulates that “*No officer may publish, or communicate to unauthorized persons, or make private copies of, documents or information obtained in his official capacity, without the approval of his Head of*

Department. Where such documents or information are primarily the concern of another department, or jointly of a number of departments, the officer's Head of Department should consult the other departments concerned. In the event of doubt or disagreement, the approval of the Secretary for the Civil Service should be obtained."

- 4.1.7 For non-civil service contract staff, the employment contracts stipulate that *"The employee is subject to the provisions of the Prevention of Bribery Ordinance and the Official Secrets Ordinance, Departmental Instructions and to any Ordinances or Regulations which apply to the office or to the department to which he is appointed."*
- 4.1.8 For TCAs employed through contractors, WSD's contracts with the contractors stipulate that *"The Contractor undertakes that the Contractor and his employees will keep in confidence and not disclose to any third party without the WSD's prior consent any materials, drawings, design or information acquired from the WSD other than disclosure to those persons to whom it is necessary to supply such information to enable performance of the contract."*
- 4.1.9 To ensure TCAs employed through contractors to work on the CCBS recognize their responsibilities concerning data confidentiality, they are required to declare their knowledge of and agreement to the concerned provisions of their contracts. They should sign their declarations in the witness of the respective contractors.
- 4.1.10 Users should note that the above list of provisions is by no means exhaustive. There may be other legal, contractual, government provisions or the like with which users shall comply.

The Need-to-Know Principle

- 4.1.11 Further to Section 11.2.2 of the ITSP (Version 6.0) about granting data access rights to users on a need-to-know basis, users shall only access customer information for the purpose of discharging official duties.
- 4.1.12 Divisional / Sectional / Unit heads shall arrange for surprise-checks on the users of their work units from time to time to ensure the need-to-know principle is upheld. In a surprise-check, the concerned user should be invited to justify why he/she needs to know the information he/she has accessed.

The Least Privilege Principle

- 4.1.13 Further to Section 9.1.7 of the ITSP (Version 6.0), users should only be provided with the minimum access rights they need for the purpose of discharging official duties.

- 4.1.14 Divisional/Sectional/Unit heads shall review on a regular basis, such as at divisional meetings, as to the access rights of the users in their work units. Any requests for changing access rights should be directed to the ITPMRU in accordance with paragraph 12 of the User Administration Guide, which is posted on the TSD Homepage of the Department's Intranet.

Equipment Security and Password Management

- 4.1.15 Further to Section 11.3 of the ITSP (Version 6.0), users should take precautions against unauthorized access to the CCBS through computers in their possession. Precautions may include-
- users should in no circumstances allow their computers, especially those they share with other colleagues, be left unattended after logging on to CCBS;
 - users should log out from the CCBS properly;
 - users should keep their passwords strictly confidential.

Printouts

- 4.1.16 Users should not print information, particularly sensitive personal information of customers, out from the CCBS unless it is necessary to do so for the purpose of discharging official duties. Users in possession of a printout of CCBS information will be held personally responsible for the security of the information; they must guard against unauthorized access to the printout and must destroy the printout once its reasons for existence are served.

Compliance with the Confidentiality Requirements

- 4.1.17 The protection of customer information requires the joint efforts and alertness of all users. Users and supervisors are therefore reminded of the importance of compliance with the security requirements/instructions set out in this Section and that a breach of the security requirements/instructions without satisfactory explanations may result in disciplinary action.

4.2 Security of Official Information

- 4.2.1 Attention shall be drawn to DI No. 64 paragraph 1, which states that *"Security is the personal responsibility of every Government employee. Improper disclosure of official information is contrary to the best interests of Government, the public in general and those of this Department in particular and must be guarded against by the observance of Security and other Government Regulations."* Furthermore, Government Security Regulations Clause 191 also states that *"Information without any security classification should also be protected to preserve its availability and integrity"*.
- 4.2.2 All CS staff should be well aware that every Government employee has the duty to take care of official information. In particular, all internal instructions relating to CS matters promulgated in the form of S&DBI and the S&DB Handbook (Customer Services) should be for internal use only and not to be disclosed to the public. In this connection, all new internal Instructions should contain phrasal text "For internal use only and not to be disclosed to the public" for avoidance of doubt.

4.3 Arrangement in Issuing Letters Prescribing Action Due Dates

Improvement Measures

- 4.3.1 Letters/notices prescribing action due dates are issued by WSD staff from time to time, e.g. repair notices, disconnection notices, etc. When issuing such letters/notices, Regional staff should be mindful of the lead time required for processing and mailing the letters/notices. The workflow in handling letters/notices prescribing action due dates should be streamlined as and when necessary.
- 4.3.2 The revised workflow in issuing Form WWO 47 described below is an example of streamlining workflow:-

DI No. 919 stipulates that disconnection notice (Form WWO 47) should be issued within 3 working days after Form WWO 48 re-inspection. To ensure that the requirement can be complied with, the four Regions agreed to revise the workflow in issuing Form WWO 47. After completion of Form WWO 48 re-inspection, the subject CSI should prepare the Form WWO 47 and submitted it on file directly to the responsible Engineer for consideration and signature, and copy the Form WWO 47 to his AI and I for reference. The responsible Engineer after signing the Form WWO 47, should arrange to post it by GR/Region direct instead of by routing it to DMC for further printing and mailing. The signed Form WWO 47 should then be scanned and recorded in the CCBS. The above new arrangement has shortened the time for issuing Form WWO 47.

- 4.3.3 CEs/Region should remind all relevant staff to be mindful of :-
- the lead time required for routing draft letters/officers through different ranks of officers for review before issuing; and
 - the lead time required for printing and mailing the letters/notices by DMC.

- 4.3.4 Officers should make reference to the above example to streamline the workflow in handling letters/ notices prescribing action due dates when necessary.

4.4 Reporting of Potential Fire Hazards During Inspection

CS Staff should report the potential fire hazards discovered during inspection according to DI No. 908.

4.5 Familiarising with Instructions and Experience Sharing in Inspection and Other Works

- 4.5.1 All CS staff should be familiar with the content and the purposes of all instructions and guidelines on customer services function issued in the form of S&DBI and S&DB Handbook (Customer Services). Experience sharing sessions should be conducted periodically and a record of such sessions should be kept in the format as in Table A of **Appendix 4.1**.
- 4.5.2 Upon completion of difficult or special cases, the SE/Region(CS), E/Region(CS) or CWI/Region(CS)(W) should arrange a debriefing session with relevant staff for experience sharing. A record of such sessions should be kept in the format shown in Table B of **Appendix 4.1**.
- 4.5.3 The records of experience sharing sessions (Table A) and debriefing sessions (Table B) should be reported in the Preventive Action Meeting cum CS Functional Meeting and they should be passed to CE/TS together with the minutes of the meetings. CE/TS will arrange to upload the minutes to TSD webpage for reference of colleagues.
- 4.5.4 E/Region(CS)(I) should remind his front line staff to inspect the related installations of water supply system(s) during investigation, inspection of repairs, replacement of water meters etc.
- 4.5.5 When there is a need to change the repair works specified in WWO 48 which has already been issued to the consumer, the CS Inspection Team should, in addition to giving the consumer concerned a verbal advice, issue a new Form WWO 48 to replace the former one the soonest possible.

4.6 Compliance with Requirements and Procedures Stipulated in Circular Letters and Internal Instructions

- 4.6.1 To avoid inconsistent practices adopted by individual officers or between various Region (CS), all CS staff shall strictly adhere to the requirements and procedures laid down in Circular Letters and relevant internal instructions, including interim measures promulgated through S&DBI. In this regard, the following new procedures are to be followed:
- 4.6.1.1 After promulgation of a new Circular Letter or a new internal instruction, SE/Region(CS) should arrange and conduct a discussion session with the relevant sub-ordinates (desirably within 2-3 working days) to thoroughly brief them on the new requirements and procedures and to elaborate the implementation details for standardizing the handling procedure. Wherever situation warrants, the respective E, CWI and Inspectorate staff of Region(CS) should assist in cascading same messages further downwards to other frontline staff as soon as possible.
- 4.6.1.2 If there is any problem or doubt in the implementation of the new requirements and procedures, CS staff should timely report the same to the SE/E/CWI for seeking guidance/clarification. If the issue cannot be resolved or answered at the Regional level, SE/Region(CS) should escalate the issue and seek guidance/clarification from CE/TS or TSU. SE/Region(CS) shall continuously monitor the implementation of all new requirements and procedures, collect feedback and take necessary action in timely manner on any problem identified.

4.7 Arrangement of Training in Customer Services Section under the ISO Integrated Quality Management System (IQMS)

- 4.7.1 Under the ISO IQMS, CC Section is tasked to deal with the training arrangements of CS staff, whereas each Region has its own TC. This section is to highlight some major training requirements under IQMS.

Training courses related to IQMS

- 4.7.2 For training courses directly under the area of IQMS (i.e. IQMS itself and courses directly related to staff performing duties under the CSPM), SE/Region(CS)s are required to send their nominations to CC Section (as the IQMS-TC) who will consolidate and compile a nomination list for the Training Unit via CE/TS (refers to Items 6.6.2.3 and 6.6.4.4 of IQPM).

Training courses not related to IQMS

- 4.7.3 For training courses not directly under the area of IQMS such as language and computer courses etc., there is no change to the existing practice i.e. the individual TC of each Region should send their nominations directly to the Training Unit.

Briefing training for new staff

- 4.7.4 SE/Region(CS)s have to inform the IQMS-TC on the arrival of a new staff to the Region (CS) with respect to the IQMS (refer to Item 6.6.1.1 of IQPM).
- 4.7.5 The concerned Region(CS) shall arrange an IQMS Briefing Training for the new staff by itself. The Briefing Training shall cover the quality policy, the set-up of IQMS, the applicable procedural manuals and other relevant materials of the IQMS (refer to Items 6.6.1.2 and 6.6.1.3 of IQPM). The relevant training materials for the Briefing Training can be obtained from the Integrated Quality Manual, IQPM and CSPM. SE/Region(CS)s shall inform the IQMS-TC by e-mail after conducting the training.

Filing of training records

- 4.7.6 The IQMS-TC shall file all documents related to IQMS training in the file “WSD 3608/54/1/3/1/08”.

Other requirements

- 4.7.7 The IQMS-TC and Section Heads, i.e. the SE/Region(CS)s should also note and comply with the requirements as stated in “IQPM Chapter 6: Training” such as the annual review of Training Plan and conducting of Competence Training.

4.8 Request for Confirmation on Identity of Customer Services Field Staff

- 4.8.1 From time to time, our CS field staff may be asked by the public to identify themselves during the site visits. The following guidelines should be observed when dealing with request for confirmation on identity of our CS field staff:
- 4.8.2 If situation permits, field staff of Region(CS) will normally make an appointment by phone with the relevant MO or consumer before conducting the visit. The MO or the consumer may check with the supervisor of the field staff or CTEC by phone to confirm the identity of the field staff as necessary.

- 4.8.3 Field staff are always required to wear their departmental staff cards when they are on duty. They are required to identify themselves by showing their departmental staff cards to the relevant MOs or consumers before discharging their duties on site.
- 4.8.4 If the relevant MOs or consumers wish to double check the identity of our field staff even they have seen the department staff cards, they are advised to check with the supervisors of the field staff or contact CTEC for confirmation. During office hour, if CTEC receives a phone call of this kind from the MO or consumer, CTEC should request for speaking to the field staff directly through the phone to ascertain the name and contact numbers of his supervisors. CTEC staff should immediately make a phone call to the supervisor of the concerned field staff to confirm his identity and call back the MO or consumer after checking.
- 4.8.5 Outside office hour, CTEC will ascertain the identity of the field staff by checking the name lists of the Standby Teams on duty and calling the field staff or Duty Officer of the concerned Region.
- 4.8.6 The MO or consumer is advised to report to the Police if, after our checking, the person who claimed to be a WSD staff is suspected to be an impostor.

4.9 Security of Water Supply to Essential Installations

- 4.9.1 While every effort should be made to provide continuous water supply to each and every consumer, such a service would be more important to essential consumers than non-essential consumers.
- 4.9.2 For the purpose of this section, an essential installation refers to an installation the operation of which would be detrimentally affected, and hence human life or social order would be at stake, when water supply for potable use or firefighting is not available to the installation (e.g. hospitals ³⁰, penal institutions, gas / oil depots, underground MTR interchange stations, traffic tunnels and installation provide services that affect a population of over 100,000 ³¹ such as large scale power plants and airport). Examples of essential installations include hospitals and penal institutions. A list of essential installations consolidated from previous returns by Regions is maintained at TSD Intranet. The list can be downloaded from our TSD Intranet Webpage via the following link :

³⁰ Clinics or other medical center that without surgical room should be excluded.

³¹ The population figure makes reference to the classification of Category 1 emergency incidents as stipulated in Appendix VII of the “Guidance Notes of Handling of Main Burst and Emergency Maintenance of Water Mains”.

http://intranet5.wsd.gov/division/cs/en/technical_support_unit/documents_publications/list_of_essential_installation/index.html

In the annual update of the list, SE/Regions(CS) shall suggest new potential essential installations and supplement with the shape files and remove obsolete ones. The list shall then be reviewed by SE/Regions(Distribution). Such updating shall be coordinated by TS Unit by the end of each year. In between each update, any updates should be sent to TS Unit for interim updates, if necessary.

- 4.9.3 Planned water supply interruptions to essential installations should be kept to the absolute minimum and any technical fault in the water supply should be dealt with expeditiously. In order to achieve this, CE/Regions should arrange to modify the local supply network with a view to improving the security of our water supply to these essential installations whenever practicable. Improvement works may include the provision of duplicate water supply sources to the installation.
- 4.9.4 On the other hand, most of these essential installations should have had adequately sized water storage tanks to provide reserve water supplies at times when mains water supplies are not available. Letters should be sent to the RC concerned to advise them that continuous mains water supply cannot be guaranteed, even though '24-hr water supply' might have been approved originally, and to urge them to review their water storage facilities periodically as well as to carry out any necessary improvement works to provide themselves with the desirable reserve water supplies.

4.10 Use of Standard Letters

- 4.10.1 This section serves to provide the following guidelines for CS staff concerned to use standard letters in their correspondences with the consumers
- 4.10.2 Standard letters have been produced for use by the Regions in the following manner :-
- those attached to the relevant Departmental Instructions
 - those attached to the relevant S&D Branch Instructions
 - those attached to the standard procedures such as CCBS
 - those made available by individual Regions to suit specific purposes
- 4.10.3 Standard letters of the first three categories are often produced in conjunction with the promulgation of certain departmental policies/practices to help to illustrate the policies/practices. However, standard letters are not able to cover all cases of different nature and in exercising the departmental policies/practices to deal with any of these cases,

there may be occasions when the standard letters need to be slightly modified or non-standard letters are to be used instead.

- 4.10.4 Hence, officers must use standard letters with discretion and the officers to sign the standard letters must also ensure that the standard letters are appropriate to transmit the correct messages to the addressees.

4.11 Consumer Services Inspectors – Uniforms

- 4.11.1 To maintain good image of WSD to the public, certain rank of staffs must wear uniform when they are carrying out duty outdoors. CSIs, except those working in the Prosecution Unit, must wear uniform while on duty outdoors.
- 4.11.2 The summer uniform for CSIs comprises a white short-sleeve shirt and navy blue trousers. The winter uniform comprises a white long-sleeve shirt, a navy blue jacket, navy blue trousers and a dark blue necktie with departmental logo. A navy blue overcoat and a pullover are provided for wearing during cold weather.
- 4.11.3 To allow CSIs to have adequate sets of uniform for change, they are provided with the following:

<u>Consumer Service Inspector Uniform</u>					
Summer	No.	Winter	No.	All Seasons	No.
Shirt	4	Overcoat	1	Raincoat	1
Trousers	3	Jacket	2	Badge	1
		Pullover	1	Socks	3 pair
		Shirt	3	Shoes	2 pair
		Necktie	2	Boots	1 pair
		Trousers	2		
*The suggested quantities are for reference only. The actual quantities provided should base on the operation need.					

- 4.11.4 CSIs failing to wear uniform for outdoor work, must provide an explanation in writing to his or her supervisor. Supervisor should periodically check whether their CSIs under his supervision are wearing uniform when on duty and report to the unit head any case of non-compliance.